On Becoming a Person

A Therapist's View of Psychotherapy

Carl R. Rogers

Chapter-by-chapter notes

How to read these notes

- Each Part opens with an overview page: the author's own description of the Part, its theme, how its chapters build that theme, and what it adds to the book.
- Each chapter keeps the author's own order and headings. The blue box says where the chapter sits in the argument. The gold box says how it builds the author's case.
- Words in quotation marks are the author's own. Everything else is a close paraphrase; nothing is added.
- The notes for each chapter are capped at one third of that chapter's length (a 1:3 ratio of notes to book) and are usually shorter.
- Page numbers sit on the outer edge of the footer as "page / total"; the book's name sits on the inner edge. The Contents lines are links.

> **Place in the argument**
> Blue box: the chapter's place in the book's argument.

> **How this chapter builds the author's case**
> Gold box: how the chapter builds the author's case.

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Architecture of the Book at a Glance

The book gathers papers and talks written between 1951 and 1961. Its seven Parts move from the person speaking, to the helping relationship, to the process and philosophy of becoming, to research, to the wider implications.

Part	Chapters	The question it answers	What it contributes
Introduction	To the Reader	Why gather a decade of papers, and how should they be read?	States the stakes (human tension in a scientific age) and invites a personal reading.
Part I	Chapter 1	Who is speaking, and from what experience?	Grounds every later idea in one person's lived learnings.
Part II	Chapters 2–4	How can I be of help?	Sets the conditions of a helping relationship: genuineness, acceptance, empathy.
Part III	Chapters 5–7	What happens as a person grows in therapy?	Describes the direction and the process of change.
Part IV	Chapters 8–9	What goal and good life does that growth point to?	Draws a philosophy of persons: the self one truly is, the fully functioning person.
Part V	Chapters 10–12	How can these claims be checked?	Faces the relation of persons and science and presents the research.
Part VI	Chapters 13–19	What are the implications for living?	Applies the conditions to teaching, family, communication, relationships and creativity.
Part VII	Chapters 20–21	Who will decide how the behavioral sciences are used?	Makes the person prior to science and offers a choice of values.

To the Reader

Place in the argument

The title is a direct address: Rogers explains why he gathers ten years of papers (1951–1961) before any chapter begins. His reasons run from the reader's side to his own and end on the largest stake, human tension in a scientific age. The promise at the close: "to share with you something of my experience — something of me."

- Thirty-three years as "a psychotherapist (or personal counselor)", with children and adults, "normal," "neurotic," and "psychotic" individuals ("misleading labels"), and lives "utterly desperate and without hope." "A deep privilege."
- **Personal living.** The papers have relevance "for personal living in this perplexing modern world": "in no sense a book of advice," but readers found them "challenging and enriching." He wants them open to "the intelligent layman"; the recorded interviews may leave readers "subtly enriched in courage and self confidence."
- **Requests.** Teachers, social workers, industrial leaders, political scientists and others asked for his recent thinking in "a convenient and available package."
- **Search for an audience.** He speaks to only a fraction of psychologists (who see "the individual solely as an object"), psychiatrists (for whom Freud has already voiced the truth) and counselors (focused on tests and guidance). His papers "piled up as unpublished manuscripts"; now he lets them "seek their own audience": a trend labelled "phenomenological, existential, person-centered" (Allport, Maslow, May), whose "common thread" is "their concern about the person and his becoming, in a modern world which appears intent upon ignoring or diminishing him."
- **The desperate need of our times.** Scientific advance may bring "total destruction of our world unless we can make great advances in understanding and dealing with interpersonal and intergroup tensions"; he wants "the price of one or two large rockets" spent on it. Unused learnings could develop "mature, nondefensive, understanding persons."
- **The book.** Each chapter has an introductory note; the papers run "from the highly personal to the larger social significance"; "variations on a theme" are kept; each can be read alone. His full theory is left out.
- "Here is what I have experienced in the jungles of modern life, in the largely unmapped territory of personal relationships. Here is what I have seen. Here is what I have come to believe."

How this chapter builds the author's case

The four reasons preview the book's movement from personal learning to social stakes; the final one returns in Chapters 17, 18 and 21.

PART I

Speaking Personally

The author's own description of the Part

> *"I speak as a person, from a context of personal experience and personal learnings."*

The theme of the Part

Rogers begins with himself. Before offering any theory he gives the reader the person and the history behind the ideas, so that what follows can be read as one person's learnings, not as pronouncements.

How the chapters build the theme

- Chapter 1 is the whole Part. It joins two personal talks and traces his early years, graduate training and clinical work, the lessons drawn from them, and the "significant learnings" he now holds.

What the Part contributes to the book

It sets the tone and the method: ideas grounded in lived experience, with the claim that "What is most personal is most general." Later parts state the same learnings as hypotheses, findings and implications.

CHAPTER 1

“This is Me”

The Development of My Professional Thinking and Personal Philosophy

> **Place in the argument**
>
> Rogers opens with himself because, he says, people are “hungry” to know “something of the person who is speaking to them or teaching them,” and he wants to give “more context and meaning to the chapters which follow.” The title is the question put to him by students: “How had I come to think the thoughts I had? How had I come to be the person I am?” The chapter joins two talks: a Brandeis senior-class talk and a Wisconsin “Last Lecture.” Its headings run from his early years, through the professional career that shaped his views, to “Some Significant Learnings”, which prepares every later argument.

- He begins with what psychotherapy means to him, quoting the preface to *Client-Centered Therapy*: the book “is about the suffering and the hope, the anxiety and the satisfaction, with which each therapist’s counseling room is filled.” It is about “a client in my office … struggling to be himself, yet deathly afraid of being himself”, and about himself as “a midwife to a new personality.” It is about life, with “its overbalancing thrust toward growth, if the opportunity for growth is provided.”

My Early Years

- A home of “close family ties,” “a very strict and uncompromising religious and ethical atmosphere,” and “a worship of the virtue of hard work.” He was the fourth of six; parents loving but “very controlling.” They were “different from other people”: no alcohol, dancing, cards or theater. “So I was a pretty solitary boy, who read incessantly.”
- At twelve the family moved to a farm. Two interests bore on his later work: breeding night-flying moths, and scientific agriculture. Reading Morison’s *Feeds and Feeding* he learned “how difficult it is to test an hypothesis” and gained “a respect for the methods of science in a field of practical endeavor.”

College and Graduate Education

- Began in agriculture at Wisconsin; a professor’s injunction stayed with him: “Don’t be a damned ammunition wagon; be a rifle!” His goal shifted to the ministry, then to history.
- In 1922 a World Student Christian Federation trip to China showed him “sincere and honest people could believe in very divergent religious doctrines.” There he “emancipated myself from the religious thinking of my parents”, which caused “great pain” but made him “an independent person.” He married a childhood friend as soon as he finished college.
- At Union Theological Seminary (1924) a student-run seminar with no instructor, “composed of our own questions,” moved him toward “a philosophy of life which was my own.” Most of its members “thought themselves right out of religious work.” He wanted a field where “my freedom of thought would not be limited.”

Becoming a Psychologist

- Drawn at Union to psychological and psychiatric courses, he took work at Teachers College, Columbia (Kilpatrick, Leta Hollingworth) and drifted into child guidance “with relatively little clearcut conscious choice.”
- At the new Institute for Child Guidance he met the dynamic Freudian views of the staff in conflict with the “rigorous, scientific, coldly objective, statistical” view at Teachers College. “The necessity of resolving that conflict in me was a most valuable learning experience.”
- He took a $2,900 post in Rochester, a “dead-end street professionally”; he felt that “if I was given some opportunity to do the thing I was most interested in doing, everything else would somehow take care of itself.”

The Rochester Years

- Twelve years of practical work with delinquent and underprivileged children; one criterion: “Does it work? Is it effective?” He formed his own views, through three “instances of disillusionment — with an authority, with materials, with myself”:
- (1) A pyromaniac boy: he traced the fire-setting to a sexual impulse as Healy’s writings predicted, but the boy repeated it on probation. “Healy might be wrong.”
- (2) A published model interview he once admired now looked like “a clever legalistic type of questioning”; he was “moving away from any approach which was coercive or pushing,” “not for philosophical reasons, but because such approaches were never more than superficially effective.”
- (3) A mother he could not lead to insight: both agreed to stop, then she asked, “Do you ever take adults for counseling here?” and real therapy began. It taught him “that it is the client who knows what hurts, what directions to go, what problems are crucial,” and that he should “rely upon the client for the direction of movement in the process.”

Psychologist or ?

- The university did not count his work as psychology, and APA meetings on “the learning processes of rats” seemed unrelated; psychiatric social workers “seemed to be talking my language.” Eventually the Psychology Department too listed his courses. “I have followed my own course, being relatively unconcerned with the question of whether I was going with my group or not.”

My Children

- His son and daughter taught him “far more about individuals, their development, and their relationships, than I could ever have learned professionally”; he values being able to “really communicate in a deep way” with them as adults.

Ohio State Years

- In 1940 he was offered a full professorship. Teaching graduate students, he saw he had “a distinctive point of view of my own”; his paper at Minnesota drew strong reactions: “a new idea of mine, which to me can seem all shiny and glowing with potentiality, can to another person be a great threat.” He wrote *Counseling and Psychotherapy*; the publisher doubted 2,000 copies would sell (“70,000 copies to date”). He notes “how little I have cared about being ‘realistic.’”

Recent Years

- Chicago and Wisconsin. Therapy asks “continuing personal growth on the part of the therapist” and can be “very frightening.” Therapy is “the experience in which I can let myself go subjectively”; research “in which I can stand off and try to view this rich subjective experience with objectivity… to determine whether I have been deceiving myself.” He expects “laws of personality and behavior” as significant as gravity.
- He is attacked by psychologists, educators and now psychiatrists, and harmed by uncritical “disciples”: “I have found it difficult to know, at times, whether I have been hurt more by my ‘friends’ or my enemies.” He prizes “the privilege of being alone”; his best work came in hideaways away from others’ expectations.

Some Significant Learnings

- Offered not as a guide: “these are learnings which have significance for me,” “scattered,” “not fixed.” First, relationships with others:
- **Not acting a role.** “It does not help, in the long run, to act as though I were something that I am not”; most of his failures arise when “I have, for some defensive reason, behaved in one way at a surface level, while in reality my feelings run in a contrary direction.”
- **Listening to myself.** “I am more effective when I can listen acceptantly to myself, and can be myself.” Paradox: “when I accept myself as I am, then I change”; “we cannot move away from what we are, until we thoroughly accept what we are.” Then relationships “become real.”
- **Permitting myself to understand another.** Our first reaction is “an immediate evaluation, or judgment”; “understanding is risky. If I let myself really understand another person, I might be

changed by that understanding." Understanding enriches him and lets the client accept his own feelings, and "then they find both the feelings and themselves changing."

- **Opening channels** for others' feelings: he tries a classroom climate where feelings can be expressed, with "reaction sheets" unrelated to grades.
- **Accepting another person**, including his hostility, difference or admiration; "each person is an island unto himself … he can only build bridges to other islands if he is first of all willing to be himself." Accepting "assists him to become a person."
- **Less wish to "fix things."** "I become less and less inclined to hurry in to fix things, to set goals, to mold people." Paradox: willingness to let others be themselves stirs up more change.
- Then, values and actions:
- **I can trust my experience.** "My total organismic sensing of a situation is more trustworthy than my intellect." Unconventional paths that "felt right" were later joined by colleagues.
- **Evaluation by others is not a guide.** Others' judgments ("a fraud," "a mystic," or praise) are evidence only; "only one person … can know whether what I am doing is honest, thorough, open, and sound … and I am that person."
- **Experience is the highest authority.** "Neither the Bible nor the prophets — neither Freud nor research … can take precedence over my own direct experience." It is authoritative "because it can always be checked in new primary ways."
- **I enjoy discovering order in experience.** Research and theory are "the inward ordering of significant experience"; the only sound reason for research is "to satisfy a need for meaning which is in me."
- **The facts are friendly.** Early on he regarded facts "as potential enemies"; now "every bit of evidence … leads one that much closer to what is true."
- **What is most personal is most general.** The feeling that seemed most private often found "a resonance in many other people."
- **Persons have a basically positive direction**: "positive, constructive, moving toward self-actualization, growing toward maturity, growing toward socialization." This is no "Pollyanna view"; people behave cruelly "out of defensiveness and inner fear."
- **Life is a flowing process in which nothing is fixed.** "There can be no closed system of beliefs"; hence "no philosophy or belief or set of principles which I could encourage or persuade others to have." "If there is such a thing as truth, this free individual process of search should, I believe, converge toward it."

How this chapter builds the author's case

This personal opening supplies the stock of ideas the rest of the book develops and tests: acceptance and understanding (Chapters 2–3), the client who knows the direction (Chapters 5–7), the positive direction of persons (Chapters 8–9), the "facts are friendly" (Part V), and the freedom to be oneself in teaching, family and creativity (Part VI). Rogers' trust in experience as "the highest authority" also explains why the research chapters follow his therapy.

PART II

How Can I Be of Help?

The author's own description of the Part

> *"I have found a way of working with individuals which seems to have much constructive potential."*

The theme of the Part

What makes a relationship helpful? Rogers moves from his own hypotheses, to the characteristics of the helping relationship, to what is known about psychotherapy objectively and subjectively.

How the chapters build the theme

- Chapter 2 sets out hypotheses about the relationship that facilitates personal growth.
- Chapter 3 asks the questions a helper must put to himself and turns the hypotheses into the characteristics of a helping relationship.
- Chapter 4 sets what research shows beside what clients and therapists experience.

What the Part contributes to the book

It supplies the core conditions (genuineness, acceptance, empathic understanding) on which every later application rests, in therapy, teaching, family, groups and science.

CHAPTER 2

Some Hypotheses Regarding the Facilitation of Personal Growth

Place in the argument

This 1954 Oberlin talk compresses the fundamental principles of psychotherapy into the shortest statement in the book, and Rogers notes that it gives "the facilitating relationship, and the outcomes, with no description of, or even comment on, the process by which change comes about." It therefore opens Part II by stating the claim every later chapter works out: if a certain relationship is provided, growth follows. The headings follow the three phrases of one sentence (relationship, motivation, outcomes), then widen the claim to all human relationships.

- "To be faced by a troubled, conflicted person who is seeking and expecting help, has always constituted a great challenge to me." He drew on Teachers College measurement, Freudian methods at the Institute for Child Guidance, Otto Rank and social work, but "most of all it has meant a continual learning from my own experience."

A General Hypothesis

- The change in him: early on he asked, "How can I treat, or cure, or change this person?" Now: "How can I provide a relationship which this person may use for his own personal growth?" So what he has learned applies to all human relationships.
- A negative learning: "I cannot be of help to this troubled person by means of any intellectual or training procedure." Explaining a person to himself or prescribing steps gives "some temporary change, which soon disappears, leaving the individual more than ever convinced of his inadequacy." Change "appears to come about through experience in a relationship."
- The hypothesis: "If I can provide a certain type of relationship, the other person will discover within himself the capacity to use that relationship for growth, and change and personal development will occur."

The Relationship

- **Genuineness:** "the more that I can be genuine in the relationship, the more helpful it will be"; to be aware of his own feelings rather than "an outward façade of one attitude, while actually holding another." "It seems extremely important to be real."
- **Acceptance:** "a warm regard for him as a person of unconditional self-worth — of value no matter what his condition, his behavior, or his feelings," including his fluctuating attitudes. It brings "warmth and safety."
- **Understanding:** "a sensitive empathy with each of the client's feelings." "Acceptance does not mean much until it involves understanding." This gives freedom to explore, and "complete freedom from any type of moral or diagnostic evaluation, since all such evaluations are, I believe, always threatening."
- Result: "I become a companion to my client, accompanying him in the frightening search for himself." When the client can experience these attitudes, "change and constructive personal development will invariably occur", "invariably" used "after long and careful consideration."

The Motivation for Change

- "The individual has within himself the capacity and the tendency, latent if not evident, to move forward toward maturity." Whether called "a growth tendency, a drive toward self-actualization, or a forward-moving directional tendency, it is the mainspring of life, and is, in the last analysis, the tendency upon which all psychotherapy depends." It may be "buried under layer after layer of encrusted psychological defenses" but "awaits only the proper conditions."

The Outcomes

- Here he leaves speculation for research: even a limited number of hours of such a relationship show changes "that do not occur in matched control groups." The client becomes more integrated and realistic, values himself more, is "more self-confident and self-directing," more open to experience, more accepting of others, "less frustrated by stress," "less defensive, more adaptive, more able to meet situations creatively." "There can no longer be any doubt as to the effectiveness of such a relationship in producing personality change."

A Broad Hypothesis of Human Relationships

- The excitement is that therapy is "only one instance of interpersonal relations, and … the same lawfulness governs all such relationships": parent and child (more self-directing), teacher and class ("a self-initiated learner"), administrator or leader (staff "more self-responsible, more creative"). "We are seeing the emergence of a new field of human relationships, in which we may specify that if certain attitudinal conditions exist, then certain definable changes will occur."

Conclusion

- Condition: genuineness and transparency; "a warm acceptance of and prizing of the other person as a separate individual"; "a sensitive ability to see his world and himself as he sees them." Then the other "will become more of a person, more unique and more self-expressive," more understanding of others, better able to cope. It holds with a client, students, staff, family or children.

> **How this chapter builds the author's case**
>
> Chapter 2 gives the thesis in miniature; Chapter 3 asks what research and experience say about the relationship's characteristics, and Chapter 4 about psychotherapy as a whole. The gap he notes, the process of change, is taken up in Part III.

CHAPTER 3

The Characteristics of a Helping Relationship

Place in the argument

Chapter 2 asserted what kind of relationship helps; this 1958 address to the American Personnel and Guidance Association asks it as a question and answers it twice, from research and from inside. Rogers says he likes "to bring the two worlds [objective and subjective] into close juxtaposition, even if I cannot fully reconcile them." The headings follow that plan: the question, what research gives, then "How Can I Create a Helping Relationship?" in ten personal questions.

- He has "the strong conviction — some might say it was an obsession — that the therapeutic relationship is only a special instance of interpersonal relationships in general."
- A helping relationship is one in which "one of the participants intends that there should come about, in one or both parties, more appreciation of, more expression of, more functional use of the latent inner resources of the individual." It includes parent and child, physician and patient, teacher and pupil (when growth is the intent), counselors, therapists, group leaders, administrators and consultants.

The Question

- What characteristics make a relationship help, and what make it unhelpful "even though it was the sincere intent to promote growth"?

The Answers Given by Research

- Research is "stimulating and suggestive," sampled with "oversimplification."

Studies of Attitudes

- **Baldwin (Fels):** the "acceptant-democratic" parent's children develop more intelligence, originality and emotional security; "actively rejectant" parents' children are unstable, rebellious, aggressive. Rogers suggests it applies to counselor, physician and administrator: warmth, respect for individuality, "nonpossessive caring."
- **Whitehorn and Betz:** the seven most helpful resident physicians with schizophrenics saw the patient's "personal meaning," worked toward goals oriented to the personality, used "active personal participation — a person-to-person relationship," and built trust. Rogers suspects the same for almost any helping relationship.
- **Heine:** clients of analytic, client-centered and Adlerian therapists named the same helpful elements: trust, being understood, independence in choosing. Unhelpful: lack of interest, remoteness, "over-degree of sympathy," direct advice, stress on past history.
- **Fiedler:** expert therapists of different schools form similar relationships: understanding of meanings, sensitivity to attitudes, "a warm interest without any emotional over-involvement."
- **Quinn:** understanding is judged almost as well from the therapist's statements alone, so it is "an attitude of wanting to understand which is communicated." **Seeman:** success goes with "mutual liking and respect." **Dittes:** when the therapist's acceptance dipped slightly, the client's psychogalvanic reflex deviated more: "the organism organizes against threat, even at the physiological level."
- Summary: "it is the attitudes and feelings of the therapist, rather than his theoretical orientation, which is important," and it is how the client perceives them.

"Manufactured" Relationships

- Verplanck and Greenspoon: operant conditioning of verbal behavior ("Mhm," "Good") raises chosen word classes while the person is unaware. Lindsley: a schizophrenic's "helping relationship" with a rewarding machine improved him, but when rewards stopped he regressed, suggesting "trustworthiness is important if the relationship is to be helpful."

- Harlow: infant monkeys prefer the "soft mother" even when fed by the wire one, so "no amount of direct food reward can take the place of certain perceived qualities."

Two Recent Studies

- **Ends and Page:** with hospitalized alcoholics, group therapy based on learning theory (the authors' favored approach) was "somewhat deleterious," worse than no therapy; client-centered gained most, analytic some. The clue: the therapist "permits as little of his own personality to intrude as is humanly possible." "To withhold one's self as a person and to deal with the other person as an object does not have a high probability of being helpful."
- **Halkides:** judges rating small samples from ten most- and ten least-successful cases found empathic understanding, unconditional positive regard and genuineness each tied to success (.001 level); matching intensity of expression was equivocal. These qualities were as constant early as late.

Some Comments

- Helpful relationships differ from unhelpful ones, mainly in the helper's attitudes and the other's perception of them; the studies "do not give us any final answers."

How Can I Create a Helping Relationship?

- We "cannot slavishly follow such findings in a mechanical way"; he gives instead the questions and "tentative and changing hypotheses" that guide him.
- 1. **Trustworthy:** not rigid consistency but being "dependably real"; "congruent", with awareness matching experience.
- 2. **Expressive enough** that what I am is communicated unambiguously; contradictory messages confuse and breed distrust. "It is safe to be transparently real." If he can form a helping relationship to himself he can to another.
- 3. **Positive attitudes:** warmth, caring, interest; we fear being trapped, so we keep distance through professionalization, diagnoses, evaluation. "It is safe to care."
- 4. **Strong enough to be separate**, "not … engulfed by his dependency," so that he can understand more deeply.
- 5. **Secure enough to permit his separateness**; Farson found less competent counselors induce conformity to themselves.
- 6. **Entering his world of feelings and meanings** without desire to judge; even "a bumbling and faulty attempt" at empathy helps.
- 7. **Accepting each facet**: where acceptance is conditional, "he cannot change or grow in those respects."
- 8. **Not a threat:** a word "just a little stronger than the client's feelings" makes the skin-conductance reading dip.
- 9. **Freeing him from external evaluation:** "a positive evaluation is as threatening in the long run as a negative one"; the aim is that he finds "the locus of evaluation, the center of responsibility, lies within himself."
- 10. **Meeting him as a person in process of becoming**, not bound by past labels; with Buber's "confirming the other," accepting "the whole potentiality of the other." Here "Verplanck, Lindsley, and Skinner … coming together with Buber" in that each treats the other according to a hypothesis he then confirms; he prefers confirming "a living person, capable of creative inner development."

Conclusion

- He can answer few questions with a clear yes, so "the optimal helping relationship is the kind of relationship created by a person who is psychologically mature": "the degree to which I can create relationships which facilitate the growth of others as separate persons is a measure of the growth I have achieved in myself." This work, he says, is "the problem which will determine the future of this planet," more than the physical sciences.

How this chapter builds the author's case

Chapter 3 turns Chapter 2's three conditions (genuineness, acceptance, empathy) into research evidence and into his own questions, and ends by tying the helper's growth to the client's. The study of Halkides and the Ends and Page result prepare the research arguments of Chapters 4, 11 and 12.

CHAPTER 4

What We Know About Psychotherapy — Objectively and Subjectively

> **Place in the argument**
>
> Written for physical scientists at Cal Tech (1960), this chapter closes Part II by presenting therapy twice because Rogers wanted "to make very clear that the personal subjective relationship is at least an equally fundamental part of therapeutic change." The title's dash splits the chapter: the first half states only what research supports (conditions, dynamics, process, results); the second shows the same "equation" from the inside, through the therapist's and then the client's experience. He is "especially eager to capture the way therapy feels and seems to the client."

- Progress has been made in measuring outcomes and, "in the last two or three years," in "identifying the basic conditions in the therapeutic relationship" which promote growth. Therapy "does not supply the motivation" for growth; that "seems to be inherent in the organism," but therapy plays "an extremely important part in releasing and facilitating the tendency … when this tendency has been blocked."

Objective Knowledge

- "We know" means only what has objective empirical evidence, "tentative and surely incomplete," yet "no reason to be apologetic for the small but hard-won knowledge."
- **Congruence:** change is facilitated when the therapist "is what he is," "genuine and without 'front' or facade." Like the announcer who is "putting on," incongruence is sensed; people we trust are "being what they are."
- **Unconditional positive regard:** a "warm, positive and acceptant attitude toward what is in the client," caring "in a nonpossessive way," prizing him "in a total rather than a conditional way."
- **Empathic understanding:** sensing the client's feelings and meanings "from 'inside,'" and communicating it. It is rare, because we offer "evaluative understanding from the outside" ("I understand what is wrong with you"). The therapist keeps "the separateness of his own identity."
- When the client perceives these, "therapeutic movement ensues"; "it is attitudes such as these rather than the therapist's technical knowledge and skill" that are primarily responsible.

The Dynamics of Change

- The client's reactions are "a reciprocal of the therapist's attitudes": as someone listens acceptantly he "becomes able to listen to himself"; then more acceptant of himself, as the therapist shows "consistent and unconditional positive regard"; then more congruent, dropping facades, and "at last free to change and grow in the directions natural to the human organism."

The Process

- The client moves along continua: from feelings "unrecognized, unowned, unexpressed" toward "a flow in which ever-changing feelings are experienced in the moment"; from remoteness (the intellectualizer) to "immediacy of experiencing"; from rigid construings to "changing, loosely held" ones.
- Overall, away from "fixity, remoteness from feelings and experience, rigidity of selfconcept, remoteness from people, impersonality of functioning," toward "fluidity, changingness, immediacy," "realness and closeness of relationships, a unity and integration of functioning."

The Results of Therapy

- Self-concept changes: from "unacceptable to himself" to "a person of worth, as a self-directing person." Attitudes to self run four to one negative at the start and twice as often positive in the last fifth. He is less defensive, better adjusted (Rorschach, TAT, counselor ratings), has more achievable ideals, less tension, more mature behavior "seen by others who know him well." Follow-ups at six to eighteen months show the changes persist.

- The “crude equation”: the more the client perceives the therapist as real, empathic and unconditionally regarding, “the more the client will move away from a static, fixed, unfeeling, impersonal type of functioning” toward “a fluid, changing, acceptant experiencing,” with “an alteration in personality and behavior in the direction of psychic health and maturity.”

The Subjective Picture

- Therapy in its occurrence is “a highly personal, subjective experience,” with qualities different from its external view.

The Therapist’s Experience

- “I’m a little afraid of him, afraid of the depths in him as I am a little afraid of the depths in myself.” He wants the client to know “I stand with him in his tight, constricted little world,” to be “clear and transparent,” to “go with him on the fearful journey into himself.” He may shrink from feelings the client finds and so be limited. “What I am and what I feel are good enough to be a basis for therapy, if I can transparently be what I am.”

The Client’s Experience

- Imagined in the client’s voice: fear and mistrust (“I’m sure he is” judging me); a small disclosure, then “he despises me” (but little evidence); “I find him a sort of companion”; deep fear as buried feelings flow (“as though my world is falling apart”); “I don’t know who I am any more” yet “adventurous and exhilarating”; “it is really helpful to try to listen to myself”; telling the therapist his feelings about him “seems to deepen” the relationship; then “floating along on the current of life, very adventurously, being me.” He asks whether he could be himself outside the relationship: “I wonder. Perhaps I could.”
- It “may take years. It may not … happen at all.”

> **How this chapter builds the author’s case**
>
> Chapter 4 finishes Part II’s answer to “How Can I Be of Help?”: the same three conditions as Chapters 2 and 3, but now with evidence of the process and result, and with the experience from both sides. The “process” and the client’s “flowing” sketched here are the subject of Part III.

PART III

The Process of Becoming a Person

The author's own description of the Part

> *"I have observed the process by which an individual grows and changes in a therapeutic relationship."*

The theme of the Part

What happens to the client when the conditions of Part II are present? Rogers describes the direction and nature of the change, and the process through which it unfolds.

How the chapters build the theme

- Chapter 5 describes directions seen in therapy: away from facades and "oughts," toward self-direction, openness and acceptance of others.
- Chapter 6 asks what it means to become a person, drawing on clients' own words.
- Chapter 7 offers a process conception, a continuum of change from rigidity to fluidity.

What the Part contributes to the book

It gives the observed pattern of change that Part IV generalizes into a philosophy and Part V tests as research.

CHAPTER 5

Some of the Directions Evident in Therapy

Place in the argument

Part II gave the relationship; Rogers says that here and in the next chapter the material "deals in a much more specific way with the nature of the client's experience of change in himself." Written in 1951–52, it is a chapter he has "a personal fondness" for, an effort "to let myself sense, and then express, the phenomena which seemed central to therapy." The title says "directions": he asks not what therapy can cure but what the process itself is, and follows one client, Mrs. Oak, through five directions ending in the claim that the core of the person is positive.

- Therapy shows "a lawfulness and order which is astonishing in its generality." He is annoyed by questions like "Will it cure a compulsion neurosis?": understandable, but like asking "whether gamma rays would be an appropriate cure for chilblains." They are "the wrong questions" for knowing what therapy is.
- The sounder question: once the therapist holds "deep respect and full acceptance" and communicates understanding, "then we may be sure that the process is already initiated." Then ask: "What is the nature of this process, what seem to be its inherent characteristics, what direction or directions does it take, and what, if any, are the natural end-points?" Franklin, seeing the spark from the kite-key, asked the basic question rather than the practical one; so should we, not trying "to warp that process to fit our clinical needs, or our preconceived dogma."
- He pushes beyond earlier descriptions (more insightful statements, shift in "locus of evaluation from outside to inside", and so on) to trends with no research yet, using one case, and limits himself to client-centered therapy.

The Experiencing of the Potential Self

- In the safety of the relationship the client "can let himself examine various aspects of his experience as they actually feel to him … without distorting them to fit the existing concept of self." The pattern runs from "I am a self which is different from a part of my experience" to "Perhaps I am several quite different selves," to "now I am beginning to believe that I can be all of my experience."
- Mrs. Oak (housewife in her late thirties) likens therapy to handling jigsaw pieces without seeing a pattern, "a real, almost a sensuous sense": "I've never been quite so close to myself." In the sixth interview she is "singing a song," doubts it, and compares it to a blind person learning Braille. Rogers: the usual shift is from "I came here to solve problems" to "just experiencing myself."
- End point: the client "can be his experience, with all of its variety and surface contradiction; he can formulate himself out of his experience, instead of trying to impose a formulation of self upon his experience."

The Full Experiencing of an Affectional Relationship

- Therapy is also a learning "to accept fully and freely and without fear the positive feelings of another." Mrs. Oak, between the twenty-ninth and thirtieth interviews: "I found out that you actually care how this thing goes." It is not transference or countertransference, which are "one-way and inappropriate"; this is "mutual and appropriate." The therapist's acceptance tends to become "something approaching awe" at the client's struggle "to be himself," a sense of "the underlying commonality — should we say brotherhood — of man."
- She distinguishes loving from caring: "no, I don't love, but I do care terribly." Rogers: the therapist's attitude "is devoid of the quid pro quo aspect of most of the experiences we call love," a caring "that you do not wish to interfere with his development, nor to use him for any self-aggrandizing goals." Her fear was "I would be devastated." Paradox: "I'm still in the thing alone, but I'm not." "May it not be that this excerpt portrays the heart of the process of socialization?"
- Learning in therapy is "a total, organismic, frequently non-verbal type of thing," not like memorizing nonsense syllables. Generalized: "I can permit someone to care about me, and can fully accept that caring within myself. This permits me to recognize that I care, and care deeply, for and about others."

The Liking of One's Self

- "Acceptance of self" falls short: "he actually comes to like himself," "a quiet pleasure in being one's self." Mrs. Oak (thirty-third interview): her Q-sort first card was "I am an attractive personality"; "If he's hurt, let him cry … we don't object when children feel pleased with themselves." Rogers sees "a primitive joie de vivre."
- Earlier (ninth interview) she told of "flashes of sanity" in which she felt "a whole kind of person in a terribly chaotic kind of world"; hence she focuses on feelings rather than day-to-day problems. Therapy permits the person "to experience fully, and in awareness, all of his reactions," and he then feels "a genuine appreciation of himself as a total functioning unit."

The Discovery that the Core of Personality is Positive

- "One of the most revolutionary concepts to grow out of our clinical experience": the innermost core of man "is positive in nature — is basically socialized, forward-moving, rational and realistic." It contradicts the religious view of sinful man and Freud's id ("incest, murder, and other crimes"); Maslow and Montagu are "solitary voices." He was "very slow to recognize the falseness" because therapy first uncovers hostile feelings, which are "neither the deepest nor the strongest"; the core "is the organism itself, which is essentially both self-preserving and social."
- Mrs. Oak, layer by layer: bitterness and a "murderous thing, but without violence" (eighth interview); beneath it, "It's just being terribly hurt!" (thirty-first), and she has "no desire to put her murderous feelings into action"; then, in the thirty-fourth, a "descent" to a core "totally without hate" and "bigger than" sex, which the therapist hears as "something more resembling a saint"; she doubts whether it is abnormal. In the thirty-ninth she explains hatelessness is "a far more positive thing," "a kind of freedom," where "you aren't forced to make rewards and you aren't forced to punish." Rogers adds that many clients reach a similar conclusion, though "not always expressed in such an emotional way"; "the deeper she dug within herself, the less she had to fear."

Being One's Organism, One's Experience

- "Psychotherapy … is a process whereby man becomes his organism — without self-deception, without distortion." Before therapy the person asks "What do others think I should do?"; during it, "How do I experience this?" and acts on "a realistic balancing of the satisfactions and dissatisfactions."
- Examples: "Perhaps I can be that person who freely experiences both love and resentment." "Perhaps I am a richly varied person whom I can enjoy and for whom I can feel sorry." What makes it possible is "the addition of awareness."
- Objection: has the beast been released? Answer: "There is no beast in man. There is only man in man, and this we have been able to release." With awareness free, we have "a balanced, realistic, self-enhancing, other-enhancing" organism; when man denies experience "then indeed we have all too often reason to fear him." His behavior "will not always be conforming. It will be individualized. But it will also be socialized."

A Concluding Comment

- "I am quite aware … of the difference between conviction and truth." He asks only that readers test the formulation against their own experience, does not apologize for speculation ("a time for speculation, and a time for the sifting of evidence"), and hopes the hunches will be put "to operational and definitive test."

How this chapter builds the author's case

This chapter opens Part III by moving from conditions (Part II) to the client's own movement. Its "experiencing of the potential self", "liking of one's self" and "organism" directions are rebuilt as a list in Chapter 6 and as a scale of stages in Chapter 7, and the positive core is the premise of the "fully functioning person" (Chapter 9). The research he says does not yet exist is the subject of Part V.

CHAPTER 6

What It Means to Become a Person

Place in the argument

Given as a talk at Oberlin in 1954, this chapter pulls Chapter 5's directions into "more completely organized form," keeping close "to the grass roots of actual experience in therapeutic interviews." Its title asks the question every client is really asking, so it first states that question, then how the person drops masks (the two process headings), and finally "The Person Who Emerges", with four trends named by exact headings.

- Clients bring endless problems (a failing student, a disturbed housewife, a man who thinks forces plot against him), but the problem changes by the tenth interview. "There is perhaps only one problem": below the stated trouble "each person is asking, 'Who am I, really? How can I get in touch with this real self, underlying all my surface behavior? How can I become myself?'"

The Process of Becoming

- Given a relationship "in which he is safe and free," the client "uses it to become more and more himself."

Getting Behind the Mask

- He "begins to drop the false fronts, or the masks, or the roles." A student describes being "the oil that soothed the waters": "I don't know whether I have any convictions to stand up for." He learns that much of his feeling "is not real," "a front, behind which he has been hiding"; that he is guided "by what he thinks he should be, not by what he is."
- Kierkegaard, quoted: the commonest despair is "not choosing, or willing, to be oneself"; the deepest is to choose "to be another than himself"; "to will to be that self which one truly is, is indeed the opposite of despair."
- Removing a mask is frightening: a client describes "a dam holding back violent, churning waters"; when she let go she felt "self pity, then hate, then love," and then "I was moving forward."

The Experiencing of Feeling

- In therapy feelings can be experienced "clear to the limit of what they are," "a 'pure culture,'" so that "the person is his fear, or he is his anger, or he is his tenderness." A graduate student, fearing loss of his thesis and of the relationship, finds himself begging with hands together: "Who, me, beg?" Rogers: "At that moment he is nothing but his pleadingness, all the way through." Experiencing every organismic emotion this way, "he has become what he is."

The Discovery of Self in Experience

- A client's image of scattered pieces: "left to themselves the jumbled pieces fall quite naturally into their own places… You must even let your own experience tell you its own meaning; the minute you tell it what it means, you are at war with yourself." Rogers' reading: "the real self is something which is comfortably discovered in one's experiences, not something imposed upon it." The client becomes "a living, breathing, feeling, fluctuating process — in short, he becomes a person."

The Person Who Emerges

- "What kind of person lies underneath?" No one fully exemplifies these trends, and each person is "separate and distinct and unique."

Openness to Experience

- "It is the opposite of defensiveness." Evidence contrary to our self-picture is distorted; in a safe relationship the person sees "that not all trees are green, not all men are stern fathers, not all women are rejecting." He "can tolerate ambiguity" and be more realistic. A young professional can now be tired when tired, feel pain (get his back examined) and love for his daughter: "you can listen more accurately to yourself."

Trust in One's Organism

- "His own organism is trustworthy… a suitable instrument for discovering the most satisfying behavior in each immediate situation." Open to all data (his feelings, social demands, memory, the external situation), he weighs them and finds the course that best satisfies "long-range as well as immediate needs." Not infallible, but errors are corrected more quickly. Ordinarily we "include things that are not a part of our experience, and exclude elements which are" ("I can handle liquor"). Consciousness becomes "the comfortable inhabitant of a society of impulses and feelings and thoughts."

An Internal Locus of Evaluation

- "Less and less does he look to others for approval or disapproval"; the question is "Am I living in a way which is deeply satisfying to me, and which truly expresses me?" A suicidal graduate student realizes "I can't depend on someone else to give me an education… I'll really have to get it myself": "I have all the symptoms of fright," yet "a feeling of strength." Rogers: "both an invigorating and a frightening realization."

Willingness to be a Process

- The client wants a fixed state (problems solved, a good marriage) but comes "to be a process rather than a product": "a flowing river of change, not a block of solid material." A client: "I haven't finished the job of integrating and reorganizing myself, but that's only confusing, not discouraging, now." Another: "floating with a complex stream of experience."

Conclusion

- The process "is not one that occurs only in therapy"; the picture is "tentative" and he is "not saying, 'This is what you should become.'" Summary: a person "more open to all of the elements of his organic experience," "developing a trust in his own organism," who "accepts the locus of evaluation as residing within himself," and lives "in a fluid, ongoing process."

> **How this chapter builds the author's case**
>
> Chapter 6 turns Chapter 5's case-led directions into a short list of traits of the person who emerges: openness, trust in the organism, inner evaluation, being a process. Chapter 7 will treat the same change as stages, and Chapters 8 and 9 take these traits as the goal and the "fully functioning person."

CHAPTER 7

A Process Conception of Psychotherapy

Place in the argument

After the APA's Distinguished Scientific Contribution Award (1956), Rogers spent a year trying "to understand the process by which personality changes." Chapters 5 and 6 viewed therapy "from within the client's frame of reference"; this chapter instead captures "qualities of expression which may be observed by another," and so turns the process into a seven-stage continuum, the basis of the "Scale of Process in Psychotherapy." The headings first give the puzzle, method and assumed condition, then walk the stages in order, and end with open questions.

- The scale has reasonable inter-judge reliability; more successful cases show greater movement, and "successful cases begin at a higher level … than do unsuccessful cases." So "we do not yet know … how to be of therapeutic help to individuals whose behavior … is typical of stages one and two."

The Puzzle of Process

- A "journey of exploration" that has advanced "only a few short miles into the jungle." As psychologists study invariant aspects of personality, he has been interested in "the invariant aspects of change in personality." Outcome studies, even segmented ones, give "little clue as to the process." Objective research "slices through the frozen moment"; understanding of ongoing movement usually comes from theory.

A Rejected Method

- He considered translating therapy into communication, learning or systems theory but concluded that in "so new" a field what is needed first is "to steep oneself in the events," with "as few preconceptions as possible," "a naturalist's observational, descriptive approach."

The Mode of Approach

- "I used myself as a tool": his years as therapist and as client, but also his biases. He listened "as naively as possible" to recorded interviews, then abstracted "the simplest abstractions"; Gendlin, Kirtner and Zimring helped. He reports no empirical test: if it fits other therapists' experience, research will follow.

The Difficulties and Excitement of the Search

- "Nine-tenths of research is always submerged"; he shares the personal process. Observations: feelings "hit" the client ("wham!"), "bubble up," "seep through"; clients seek "exactness of symbolization"; "moments of movement" with physiological signs; and despair in "the incredible complexity." "We can scarcely dare to hope that we can discover order in it."

A Basic Condition

- As plants need constant sun, moisture and warmth, he assumes one condition: "that the client experiences himself as being fully received," psychologically received "just as he is," empathically and acceptingly. It is the client's experience of it that makes it optimal.

The Emerging Continuum

- Not "fixity … through change to a new fixity," but "from fixity to changingness, from rigid structure to flow, from stasis to process." The qualities of the client's expression show where he stands. Seven stages are a convenience; "it is a continuum." A client clusters in a narrow range, but the stages apply most exactly within a given area of personal meanings.

Seven Stages of Process

- A scheme for judging the position from "the qualities of experiencing and expressing" where the client feels completely received.

First Stage

- Unwillingness to communicate self, "only about externals" ("it always seems a little bit nonsensical to talk about one's self except in times of dire necessity"); feelings "neither recognized nor owned"; constructs "extremely rigid"; close relationships "dangerous"; "no problems are recognized" ("I think I'm practically healthy"). "Structure-bound": reacting to now as to a past experience. Such a person does not come voluntarily.

Second Stage of Process

- When he feels fully received, a "slight loosening and flowing": talk about non-self topics; problems "external to self"; feelings as unowned or "past objects" ("The symptom was … just being very depressed"); constructs thought of as "facts" ("I can't ever do anything right"); contradictions unrecognized. Many who seek help are here, and therapists have "a very modest degree of success" with them.

Stage Three

- More talk about "the self as an object," as "a reflected object, existing primarily in others," and about past feelings; "very little acceptance of feelings" (shameful, bad); constructs recognized as constructs ("I expect I felt I deserved to be punished"); a sharper differentiation; recognition of contradictions; choices "ineffective." "Many people who seek psychological help are at approximately the point of stage three."

Stage Four

- Felt understood, the client loosens: more intense "not-now-present" feelings ("it hit me down deep"), feelings as present objects, occasional present feelings breaking through ("Oh, all right, I don't trust you"); fear of immediacy; experiencing "less remote"; constructs questioned (humor "has been my bulwark"); concern about incongruence; self-responsibility that vacillates; risking a relationship on "a feeling basis." Stages three and four "constitute much of psychotherapy as we know it." A client is never wholly in one stage, but within one area of meaning stage three would rarely come before two, nor four follow two without three.

The Fifth Stage

- Feelings "expressed freely as in the present," close to being fully experienced and "bubbling through" despite fear; a dawning "direct referent" inside ("I really don't have my finger on it"); surprise and fright at feelings; owning of the "real me"; experiencing with little postponement; fresh discoveries of constructs as constructs ("I have to please"); exact differentiation; facing contradictions ("My conscious mind tells me I'm worthy. But some place inside I don't believe it"); self-responsibility; internal dialogues. It is "several hundred psychological miles" from the first stage.

Examples of Process in One Area

- Shlien's client was at stages three and four generally, but on sexual problems began at stage two (an unexplained itch, "almost inaudibly"), moved through "I'm just bad, dirty" (three), questioning her construct (four), saying "You're a man, a good looking man" to the therapist, and finally "Or am I really lucky?", a stage-five quality. This takes weeks or months and is irregular.

The Sixth Stage

- "A very crucial one": a previously "stuck" feeling "is experienced with immediacy now," "flows to its full result," and is accepted. A young man: "It's almost as if I loved myself — you know — that's strange — but it's true" ("Woof!!"). "Self as an object tends to disappear. The self, at this moment, is this feeling." Physiological loosening (moist eyes, tears, sighs); the "umbilical" gesture. The moment is integration: incongruence "disappears into congruence"; the construct dissolves, leaving the client "cut loose", which is "wondrous and frightening." The experience becomes "a referent" he can return to. Problems are no longer "external or internal": "he neither perceives his problem nor deals with it. He is simply living some portion of it knowingly and acceptingly." These moments are "in some sense almost irreversible."

The Seventh Stage

- Here the therapist's reception is less necessary and the stage "occurs as much outside of the therapeutic relationship as in it." New feelings with immediacy and richness, used as "a clear referent" to know "who he is, what he wants"; "a basic trust in his own process"; "process experiencing," interpreting the past "only to the extent that the now is identical with the past"; the self "subjective and reflexive awareness of experiencing"; constructs "tentatively reformulated"; free internal communication; "the experiencing of effective choice." The client's image: ideas develop "like the latent image coming out when you develop a photograph." Few reach it fully; the person "lives fully in himself as a constantly changing flow of process."

Some Questions Regarding This Process Continuum

- Whether it is the only process of change he does not know; "therapeutic approaches which place great stress on the cognitive … may set in motion an entirely different process." Not everyone values fluidity ("a social value judgment"). Change is slow: a client may go from about stage two to stage four with satisfaction; stage one to seven would take years. The groupings may contain errors, which research can test.

Summary

- The process involves a loosening of feelings (remote and unowned → owned, present, flowing); of the manner of experiencing (remote → an inner referent → a fluid process); a shift from incongruence to congruence; willingness to communicate self; loosening of cognitive maps; changed relation to problems (unrecognized → self-responsibility → living them); change in relating (close relationships dangerous → open and immediate). At the peak these threads are "inseparably woven together": "he has become an integrated process of changingness."

> **How this chapter builds the author's case**
>
> Chapter 7 completes Part III by making Chapters 5 and 6 observable and testable: the "flow," "organismic" trust and "becoming a process" named there become stages one to seven. Its stage-seven person leads to Part IV's question of what goals and "good life" follow from therapy (Chapters 8 and 9), and the scale itself returns as a research instrument in Part V.

PART IV

A Philosophy of Persons

The author's own description of the Part

> *"I have formed some philosophical impressions of the life and goal toward which the individual moves when he is free."*

The theme of the Part

From what clients become, Rogers draws a view of the goal and of the good life, and what he takes to be the nature of the person.

How the chapters build the theme

- Chapter 8 states the personal goal as being "that self which one truly is."
- Chapter 9 gives a therapist's view of the good life, the fully functioning person.

What the Part contributes to the book

It turns clinical observation into an explicit value orientation and the claim of a basically trustworthy organism, which Part V puts to the test and Parts VI–VII apply.

CHAPTER 8

“To Be That Self Which One Truly Is”

A Therapist’s View of Personal Goals

Place in the argument

Part IV turns from the process of change to what the individual is moving toward. Delivered at Wooster College (1951), this chapter opens it with life’s oldest question, “What is my goal in life?”, and answers with Kierkegaard’s phrase, which Rogers uses as title and goal. He says it expresses two themes he holds: “my confidence in the human organism, when it is functioning freely” and “the existential quality of satisfying living.” The headings run from the question and other answers, through the client’s negative and positive movements, to misapprehensions and social implications.

- Psychologists treat “philosophical thoughts” as an insult; he does not. He puts the existential theme in Lao-tzu’s words: “The way to do is to be.”

The Questions

- “What is my goal in life?” “What am I striving for?” Old questions each must answer “in his own way.” He asks only to share “what human beings appear to be striving for, when they are free to choose.”

Some Answers

- Past answers: to glorify God, prepare for immortality, satisfy every sensual desire, achieve possessions, status or power, serve a cause like Christianity or Communism, Hitler’s “master race,” the Oriental’s elimination of desire. Charles Morris’ study of students in six countries found five dimensions: responsible moral participation; vigorous action overcoming obstacles; a self-sufficient inner life; receptivity to persons and nature; sensuous self-enjoyment.

Another View

- None of Morris’ dimensions captures what he sees in clients, which is best put as “to be that self which one truly is.” It sounds “so simple as to be absurd,” but implies “strange things,” views he would not have held “ten or fifteen years ago.” He asks critical scepticism.

Directions Taken by Clients

- With a climate of safety, warmth and empathy, and no diagnosis or guidance, the trends “appear to me to come from the client himself” (though he cannot rule out some subtle initiation by himself).

Away From Facades

- The client moves “away from a self that he is not”: a boy says “I’m afraid they’ll find it out” that “I’m not so hot”; expressing the fear is already “coming closer to being himself.”

Away From “Oughts”

- Away from “the compelling image of what he ‘ought to be’”: a young woman finds she does not want to be a submissive “door mat” to win love; a young man: “Being ashamed of me was the way I just had to be… I’m not going to feel ashamed of myself!”

Away From Meeting Expectations

- Away from what the culture expects: Whyte’s “organization man”; Jacob’s finding that college “socialize[s] the individual.” Free clients “resent and … question” being moulded: “I’ve been so long trying to live according to what was meaningful to other people.”

Away From Pleasing Others

- A professional man: “The hell with it! I think from now on I’m going to just be me.” Summary: clients define their goal negatively; they do not choose “anything which is artificial, anything which is imposed, anything which is defined from without.”

Toward Self-Direction

- First positive trend: “he chooses the goals toward which he wants to move. He becomes responsible for himself.” It is “a frighteningly responsible freedom” and not always sound; “one chooses — and then learns from the consequences.”

Toward Being Process

- Clients are “not disturbed to find that they are not the same from day to day”; “It’s an adventure … into the unknown.” Kierkegaard: the existing individual “is constantly in process of becoming.” He moves toward “a process of potentialities being born, rather than being or becoming some fixed goal.”

Toward Being Complexity

- A counselor wanted to be aware of the full complexity of his feelings toward a difficult client (warmth, annoyance, fear, concern about reputation): “if he could be, quite openly and transparently, all of his complex … feelings … all would go well.” A “difficult, and in its absolute sense an impossible goal,” yet a clear trend.

Toward Openness to Experience

- A client moves to “an open, friendly, close relationship to his own experience.” The stutterer: “I never realized that, I never knew that.” “Gradually clients learn that experiencing is a friendly resource, not a frightening enemy”; one says “Now what is it I’m feeling? I want to get next to it.” Maslow’s self-actualizing people show “a superior awareness of their own impulses.”

Toward Acceptance of Others

- As the client accepts his own experience, “he also moves toward the acceptance of the experience of others,” as Maslow’s people look on human nature “without either arguing the matter or demanding that it be otherwise.”

Toward Trust of Self

- He “trusts and values the process which is himself.” El Greco, Hemingway and Einstein trusted their own experiencing against “good artists do not paint like that.” This is “not a phenomenon which occurs only in the artist or the genius”; simple people become “significant and creative” as they trust inner processes.

The General Direction

- “The individual moves toward being, knowingly and acceptingly, the process which he inwardly and actually is,” neither “more than he is” (insecurity or bombast) nor “less” (guilt or self-depreciation). “You mean if I’d really be what I feel like being, that that would be all right?” His experience tends to answer yes.

Some Misapprehensions

- Where objectors differ in values he respects the difference; but some objections are mistaken.

Does It Imply Fixity?

- No: “To be what one is, is to enter fully into being a process. Change is facilitated, probably maximized.” It is the person who denies his feelings who is “fixed in these behaviors which he dislikes.”

Does It Imply Being Evil?

- Nearly every client fears “catastrophe” if feelings flow. Experience contradicts it: he can be his anger, fear, self-pity, sexual or hostile feelings and “the roof of the world does not fall in”; feelings find “a total harmony,” balanced by tenderness, zest, courage. On the “beast”: the lion kills when hungry but does not go on “a wild rampage of killing”; he is “a constructive and trustworthy member of the species.” To be a unique human “is a positive, or a constructive, or a realistic, or a trustworthy process.”

Social Implications

- Could groups or nations choose this direction? American diplomacy speaks as though always moral, consistent, unselfish and never mistaken; from an individual we would call it a facade. If we were openly what we are (strong, clumsy, inconsistent, frightened of Communism, competitive, with selfish oil interests, but respecting individual dignity), we would be "much more comfortable," could "focus on the problem at hand," would be "much less feared," and would draw out openness. "It is a richly rewarding experience to be what one deeply is."

Summary

- Clients move away from concealment and others' expectations; toward being "the changing, fluid, process which he is," listening to himself, accepting others, trusting inner processes: "creatively realistic, and realistically creative." It is "not an easy direction … nor one which is ever completed." It is "a value choice which is decidedly at variance with the goals usually chosen," offered "for your consideration."

> **How this chapter builds the author's case**
>
> Chapter 8 takes the client's movement traced in Chapters 5 to 7 and states it as a goal of life, giving the human aim Part IV asks for; Chapter 9 sets the same direction as a general portrait, "the fully functioning person." The fear that being oneself means being evil is answered here by the positive core argued in Chapter 5.

CHAPTER 9

A Therapist's View of the Good Life: The Fully Functioning Person

Place in the argument

Part IV's second chapter asks what person emerges "if therapy were maximally successful." Rogers wrote "The Concept of the Fully Functioning Person" about 1952–53 and was "somewhat frightened by the fluid, relativistic, individualistic person who seemed to be the logical outcome." Two questions followed: "Was my logic correct? If correct, was this the sort of person I valued?" He presents here a briefer, "more readable" version, with the old title as subtitle. The headings move from what the good life is not, to what it is, to its three characteristics, to implications.

- His views "are largely based upon my experience" in therapy, "an empirical or experiential foundation," from client-centered therapy. He first sketches therapy at its optimum: therapist and client "as a person to a person"; the therapist feels the client is "of value no matter what his condition," is genuine and empathic; the client explores "increasingly strange and unknown and dangerous feelings," and becomes "his fear, or his anger, or his tenderness", finding "his behavior changing in constructive fashion."

A Negative Observation

- "The good life is not any fixed state": not virtue, contentment, nirvana, happiness, adjustment, fulfillment, actualization, drive-reduction or homeostasis. Clients who moved most "would consider themselves insulted" if called "adjusted," and would call "happy" or "contented" false.

A Positive Observation

- "The good life is a process, not a state of being. It is a direction, not a destination." Definition: "the process of movement in a direction which the human organism selects when it is inwardly free to move in any direction, and the general qualities of this selected direction appear to have a certain universality."

The Characteristics of the Process

- Three qualities appear "person after person."

An Increasing Openness to Experience

- "The polar opposite of defensiveness": threatening experiences are "distorted in awareness, or … denied." "I quite literally cannot see, with accuracy, those experiences … significantly at variance with the picture of myself." Fully open, every stimulus would be relayed "without being distorted," and the person would be more open to "fear and discouragement and pain" and to "courage, and tenderness, and awe."

Increasingly Existential Living

- "An increasing tendency to live fully in each moment": each moment is new, so "What I will be in the next moment … cannot be predicted in advance." "The self and personality emerge from experience, rather than experience being translated or twisted to fit preconceived self-structure." Most of us "cram and twist the experience to fit our preconceptions." He calls this "almost … the most essential quality."

An Increasing Trust in His Organism

- Instead of codes, others' judgment ("Emily Post") or past behavior, such persons trust their "total organismic reaction" because "doing what 'feels right' proves to be a competent and trustworthy guide." His analogy is "a giant electronic computing machine" that takes all the data and computes "the most economical vector of need satisfaction." Errors come from including data that doesn't belong (memories fed in "as if they were this reality") or excluding data (threatening experience). It

is not infallible, but openness means errors are "quickly corrected." Clients are "surprised at their own intuitive skill."

The Process of Functioning More Fully

- Summary: he lives "fully in and with each and all of his feelings," uses all his organism to sense the situation, trusts it "not because it is infallible, but because he can be fully open to the consequences of each of his actions," is "his own sifter of evidence," "soundly and realistically social," and so "a more fully functioning person."

Some Implications

- Implications offered as "food for thought."

A New Perspective on Freedom vs. Determinism

- The paradox: the client feels "the power of naked choice," yet research assumes "a complete determinism." In the fully functioning person, choice and determination coincide: he "wills or chooses" the course that is also "absolutely determined" by all factors; the defensive person "cannot behave in the fashion that he chooses" because his defensiveness is among the determinants. Not a full resolution, but "the more the person is living the good life, the more he will experience a freedom of choice."

Creativity as an Element of the Good Life

- Such a person is creative, "almost certainly not a conformist," would live constructively in any culture and be "a fit vanguard of human evolution," the type likely to "adapt and survive."

Basic Trustworthiness of Human Nature

- "The basic nature of the human being, when functioning freely, is constructive and trustworthy"; "we do not need to ask who will socialize him," since affiliation is a deep need; no need to ask who will control aggression. "Man's behavior is exquisitely rational"; the tragedy is that "our defenses keep us from being aware of this rationality." The only control needed is "the natural and internal balancing of one need against another."

The Greater Richness of Life

- Wider range: pain and ecstasy, anger and love, fear and courage. Fitting adjectives: "enriching, exciting, rewarding, challenging, meaningful." "Not … a life for the faint-hearted … It involves the courage to be." "When the individual is inwardly free, he chooses as the good life this process of becoming."

How this chapter builds the author's case

Chapter 9 completes Part IV: Chapter 8 gave the goal as a client's direction; this one generalizes it as the "fully functioning person," built from the openness, trust and fluidity of Chapters 5–7. Its claim of a "basic trustworthiness" is the one Part V tests (Chapters 10–12) and Part VI applies to teaching, family and creativity.

PART V

Getting at the Facts: The Place of Research in Psychotherapy

The author's own description of the Part

> *"I have endeavored to check my clinical experience with reality, but not without some philosophical puzzlement as to which "reality" is most valid."*

The theme of the Part

How can the claims of therapy be checked? Rogers faces the relation of subjective experience to scientific method and presents the evidence.

How the chapters build the theme

- Chapter 10 asks, as a philosophical question, how persons and science are related.
- Chapter 11 describes research on personality change in psychotherapy.
- Chapter 12 places client-centered therapy within its context of research.

What the Part contributes to the book

It gives the empirical grounding for the hypotheses of Parts II–IV, and prepares the discussion of science and persons in Part VII.

CHAPTER 10

Persons or Science? A Philosophical Question

Place in the argument

Opening Part V, this is the chapter in which Rogers faces the question underneath all research on therapy: can a relationship he lives as "almost mystical subjectivity" also be studied by the "rigorous objectivity" of science? Written "solely for myself" while he was "wintering in Taxco" and finished a year later, it is built as a drama whose characters are all inside him: first protagonist (therapist), second protagonist (scientist), "The Conflict," and "The Resolution." He says it "makes clear the reason for my 'double life' of subjectivity and objectivity." The conflict was between the logical positivism of his education and the existential thought of Kierkegaard and Buber which "fit so well with my therapeutic experience."

- Kierkegaard's writings "loosened me up and made me more willing to trust and express my own experience." The paper is "a highly personal document … of interest to others only to the extent that the issue exists for them."

Introduction

- "The better therapist I have become … the more I have been vaguely aware of my complete subjectivity"; as a better investigator he feels "increasing discomfort at the distance between the rigorous objectivity of myself as scientist and the almost mystical subjectivity of myself as therapist." His method: first let go as therapist, then as scientist, then conduct the debate; the first draft "only sharpened the conflict." A seminar and a year's thought brought "a tentative and perhaps temporary integration."

The Essence of Therapy in Terms of its Experience

- He enters the relationship "not as a scientist, not as a physician who can accurately diagnose and cure, but as a person"; "insofar as I see him only as an object, the client will tend to become only an object." He risks himself and "it is my total organism which takes over." At depth there is "a unity of experiencing": the client experiences feeling as "a 'pure culture,'" and he understands without diagnostic thought, a "trance-like" "I-Thou" relationship (Buber), "the height of personal subjectivity." He often does not know where it leads: both "slip into the stream of becoming."
- The client dares to become himself; consciousness "becomes the comfortable inhabitant of a richly varied society of impulses." He experiences "naked choice"; being himself "doesn't 'solve problems'" but gives "more depth and more height," more aloneness but deeper relationships.
- It is also learning, of "a strange type": simple, self-appropriated ("I do feel sorry for myself," "I could be what I want to be"), like the child who suddenly finds "two and two do make four." It matches symbols to feelings: the client "must learn the language of feeling … as if he were an infant learning to speak." It "cannot be taught": "the more he learned this, the less he would have learned it in the significant, experiential, self-appropriating way" (Kierkegaard's "true subjectivity"). Essence: to realize "the total, unified, immediate, 'at-this-instant,' state of the organism which is me."

The Essence of Therapy in Terms of Science

- Science aims at "objective knowledge of events and of functional relationships between events"; prediction and control possible but not necessary; it can give only probabilities, never "absolute truth," and models become "increasingly unlike these phenomena as they are experienced." "Anything that exists can be measured."
- Three crude hypotheses: acceptance by therapist leads to client self-acceptance; the more the therapist sees a person rather than an object, the more the client does; experiential learning occurs. Each could be operationally defined (attitude tests, Q-sorts, physiological measures, control groups). Objectivity "rests upon its method, not upon its content" (Stephenson). Supposed findings (a correlation of about .70) would give exact description, "tentative laws of the dynamics of human relationships," and "public and replicable statements."

Some Issues

- The two views seem “basically antagonistic.”

The Scientist’s Questions

- (1) How do you know your account is true? Otherwise “Yogi, Christian Science, dianetics, and the delusions of a psychotic individual who believes himself to be Jesus Christ” are equally true; only science gives “an ever-closer approximation to reality.” (2) Experience alone cannot find “blind spots”; science separates “the sheep of truth can thus be separated from the goats of error.” (3) Is “spontaneity … free will” defeatism? Why not seek the causes of all behavior? (4) Science underlies “almost all the advances which we value”; why doubt it in social science?

The Questions of the Experientialist

- (1) Science always concerns “the observable other”; it “never has anything to do with the experiencing me”; it can “conduct an autopsy of the dead events of therapy” but never “enter into the living physiology.” (2) It makes everything an object: if we knew all about human relationships we would “know it rather than live the relationships” (parents who know affection “is good for the child”). (3) Its end is manipulation: “a powerful tendency toward social control, toward control of the many by the few,” and toward “the weakening or destruction of the existential person”; he names Skinner’s *Walden Two* and Huxley’s *Brave New World*. (4) Ethics is more basic: unless science is “the tool of ethical persons,” it may become “a Juggernaut”; “choose we must,” and he asks that we “think long and hard before we give up the values that pertain to being a person.”

The Dilemma

- Is the problem wrongly described? Must we choose, or is there “some broader, more inclusive formulation”?

A Changed View of Science

- A year later: his “most basic error” was seeing Science as something “out there,” “a reservoir” of facts with “99% purity.”

Science in Persons

- “Science exists only in people.” “Knowledge — even scientific knowledge — is that which is subjectively acceptable.”

The Creative Phase

- Science begins in a person with personal values who “wants to find out,” immerses himself in the field as the therapist does, lets “his organism take over,” and forms a hypothesis, “a tentative, personal, subjective faith”: “I have a hunch that such and such a relationship exists.” American psychologists tend to brush this off (Spence: “simply taken for granted”) yet it is “the initial matrix.”

Checking with Reality

- Because “it is very easy to deceive ourselves,” the scientist uses operational statements, control groups, statistics: “scientific methodology is seen for what it truly is — a way of preventing me from deceiving myself.” Even so “the important choices are all made subjectively.”

The Findings

- “In the best of science, the primary purpose is to provide a more satisfactory and dependable hypothesis, belief, faith, for the investigator himself”; to prove something to others is to “bolster a personal insecurity.” A scientist may rightly say “The experiment showed thus and so, but I believe it is wrong.”

Communication of Scientific Findings

- Intersubjective verification (the blue fish on the reef) is “the beginnings of Science with a capital S.” “There is no such body of knowledge. There are only tentative beliefs, existing subjectively, in a number of different persons.” If not tentative it is dogma.

Communication to Whom?

- Findings reach only those who accept the same ground rules and are "subjectively ready to believe" (psychologists accept the lecture evidence but not ESP, doubted the Iowa studies; his own 1941 delinquency finding he could not at first believe).

The Use of Science

- "'Science' will never depersonalize, or manipulate, or control individuals. It is only persons who can and will do that." A defensive person will use it destructively; one "open to all phases of his experience" constructively. "Science can never threaten us. Only persons can do that." And therapy shows people can move toward openness.

A New Integration

- "Science is not an impersonal something, but simply a person living subjectively another phase of himself." Both therapy and science are rooted in "immediate, subjective experience"; he steps out as observer "to gain a more accurate picture of the order," using "all the canons of science." What he does with knowledge is "a matter of subjective choice" determined by openness. "For science too, at its inception, is an 'I-Thou' relationship with a person or persons."

How this chapter builds the author's case

Chapter 10 puts the philosophical ground under Part V: it answers why a therapist who trusts experience (Chapter 1, "the facts are friendly") may nevertheless test it, and it sets the ethical stakes later taken up in Chapters 20 and 21. Chapters 11 and 12 then show the research itself.

CHAPTER 11

Personality Change in Psychotherapy

Place in the argument

Having argued in Chapter 10 that science is a person's way of checking his hunches, Rogers now shows it at work: a paper for the Fifth International Congress on Mental Health (Toronto, 1954) summarizing a large Counseling Center study (1950–54, funded by the Rockefeller Foundation). He includes it because it shows "some of the exciting progress we have made in the measurement of that changing, nebulous, highly significant and determining aspect of personality, the self." The headings follow what he chooses to present: three aspects, criteria, design, and the measurement of changes in the self.

- Therapy is "a deeply subjective existential experience … full of complex subtleties," yet "if this experience is a significant one, in which deep learnings bring about personality change, then such changes should be amenable to research investigation." The research reported came after fourteen years of studies of process and outcome.

Three Aspects of Our Research

- (1) criteria that "depart from conventional thinking"; (2) a design that solves difficulties "which have hitherto stood in the way of clear-cut results"; (3) progress in "measuring subtle subjective phenomena in an objective fashion." They apply to any procedure meant to change personality.

The Criteria for the Research

- They gave up "success" and "cure" as "undefinable," "essentially value judgments," and "cure" inappropriate because the disorders are "learned behavior, not … a disease." They ask instead, "What are the concomitants of therapy?"
- Hypotheses come from the theory: denied feelings are experienced and assimilated into the self; the self becomes more congruent with the ideal self; behavior becomes "more socialized and mature"; self-acceptance rises with acceptance of others. So "many specific criterion variables" replace one global criterion, letting others "make a value judgment" on whether the changes are "success" without altering "the solid facts." This also guides the choice of instruments.

The Design of the Research

- Hebb: "there is no body of fact to show that psychotherapy is valuable"; Eysenck: data "fail to prove that psychotherapy … facilitates the recovery of neurotic patients." They aimed to show (a) whether significant change occurred and (b) whether it was due to therapy. Measures were taken before, after, and six months to a year later, on at least 25 typical clients, "an intensive study of a group of moderate size."
- Controls: an own-control group (wait two months, tested twice) accounting for motivation and personality; an equivalent-control group (matched age, status, sex, students) tested at matched intervals, some four times, accounting for "the passage of time, … random variables, … repeated administration of tests." If therapy changes exceed both, "it is reasonable to attribute these changes to the influence of the therapy."
- Complete data on 29 clients and 16 therapists, plus matched controls. Findings: "profound changes occur in the perceived self"; constructive changes "closer to the personality characteristics of the well-functioning person"; more integration and adjustment; more mature behavior as observed by friends, each significantly greater than controls. Only the hypotheses on acceptant, democratic attitudes toward others were "confused and ambiguous." So Hebb's and Eysenck's statements are modified: for client-centered therapy there is "objective evidence of positive changes … attributable to the therapy."

The Measurement of Changes in the Self

- Stephenson's Q-technique: 100 self-descriptive statements ("I am a submissive person," "I am afraid of sex") sorted into nine piles for "self as of now" and for the ideal self, before, during, after and at follow-up; sorts are correlated.

- One client (woman of 40, unhappy marriage, daughter had a breakdown; 40 interviews, then 8 more): (1) the perceived self changed more in therapy (r = .39) than in follow-up (.74, .70); (2) self–ideal congruence rose from r = .21 to .79; (3) the "adjustment score" (similarity to psychologists' sort for a "well-adjusted" person) went 35, 44, 41, 52, 54, 51, as in the group, with no change in controls. She sees herself as more self-confident, less guilty, resentful and driven.
- Extra findings: the ideal self is much more stable (correlations above .70) so the self, not the values, changes; her ideal became "less punishing"; the "remembered self" was much less favorable than her initial self-picture (adjustment 26 against 35), a crude measure of reduced defensiveness.
- Hypothesis: the client's self-picture becomes more congruent with a diagnostician's picture (TAT read blind, sorted on the same cards). Correlation was .00 at the start and .05 at the end of therapy but .56 and .55 at the follow-ups. The diagnostician saw her changing more sharply than she saw herself, against "common professional opinion that clients overrate the degree of change."

Summary and Conclusion

- Features: specific criteria instead of a global one; a doubly controlled design; progress in objectively measuring "subtle elements of the client's subjective world." Two conclusions: objective evidence of change from psychotherapy can meet "the usual canons of rigorous scientific investigation," so similar evidence can be sought for other therapies; and "the many subtleties of the therapeutic process are now wide open for research investigation," including the client-therapist relationship and "the changing source of the client's value system."

How this chapter builds the author's case

Chapter 11 answers Chapter 10 by showing that the "facts are friendly" (Chapter 1) can be obtained: the self-concept, ideal self and congruence in the Part III chapters become measured variables. Chapter 12 then places client-centered therapy in the whole research context.

CHAPTER 12

Client-Centered Therapy in Its Context of Research

Place in the argument

The chapter was written as Chapter XII of a Flemish and French book with G. Marian Kinget, to make clear "to a European audience relatively unaccustomed to the American tradition of empirical research" the methods, findings and significance of the research behind client-centered therapy. It closes Part V by stepping back from one study (Chapter 11) to twenty years of work (from about 1940 to 1961). Its headings explain why the approach stimulates research, show its early beginnings, present six "illustrative studies" in chronological order, sketch current projects, and end on what research means for the future.

- Three paragraphs on the Q-sort are repeated from Chapter 11 "so that either chapter might be read independently." The chapter "goes back to the earliest of our research efforts" and concludes with unfinished projects "in 1961."

The Stimulation of Research

- Seeman and Raskin (1953) cited nearly fifty studies; Cartwright (1957) listed 122 references. Reasons: (1) the theory has been seen "not as dogma or as truth but as a statement of hypotheses, as a tool for advancing our knowledge"; testing must be "publicly communicable and replicable"; (2) "scientific study can begin anywhere, at any level of crudity or refinement; ... a direction, not a fixed degree of instrumentation" (a recorded interview is already more objective than memory); (3) constructs are kept "operationally definable" (self-concept limited to events in awareness), which also removes "success" and "failure" as criteria; (4) constructs have generality (leadership, family climate, classroom); (5) it has lived in a university, where graduate students "question and probe," keeping it "open and self-critical, rather than ... dogmatic."

The Early Period of Research

- Until 1940 there was almost no research use of recordings. At Ohio State in 1940 a complete interview was recorded; the material seemed "so formless, so complex" that they "almost despaired," but Porter and Snyder turned it into categories of therapist techniques and client responses. "A field which is still, relatively speaking, in its swaddling clothes"; the early studies were "often unsophisticated" but "an opening wedge."

Some Illustrative Studies

- Chosen as representative of different trends, not as outstanding.

The Locus of Evaluation

- Raskin (1949): does the client's reliance on others' values decrease? Three judges agreed over 80 percent on relevant statements; twelve items formed a scale from 1.0 (reliance on others) to 4.0 (reliance on "one's own experience and judgment"). On 59 interviews in ten cases (second judge reliability .91) the first-interview mean was 1.97 and the final 2.73 (.01 level); in the five more successful cases 2.12 to 3.34. The steps typical of this research: hypothesis, instrument, test of the instrument, unbiased application, analysis. Flaws: few cases, brief therapy.

The Relation of Autonomic Function to Therapy

- Thetford (1949): "How deep are the changes?" Nineteen clients and seventeen controls were wired for GSR, heart rate and respiration and put through three digit-memory failures, before and after therapy. Therapy clients recovered faster (recovery quotient .02 level), controls slightly slower; less heart-rate variation. "After therapy the individual is able to meet, with more tolerance and less disturbance, situations of emotional stress ... in autonomic reactions which the individual cannot consciously control." A prediction "well beyond the limits of the theory as it stood" confirms it more strongly.

Client Response to Differing Techniques

- Bergman (1950): 246 instances in ten cases where the client asked for evaluation. Counselor response (evaluation-based, "structuring," request for clarification, reflection of context, reflection of the request) and the client's next expression were categorized. The initial request did not "cause" either; but reflection of feeling was followed by continued self-exploration or insight (1 percent level), while evaluative, interpretive or structuring responses were followed by "abandonment of self-exploration."

A Study of the Self-Concept

- Butler and Haigh: 25 clients and matched controls sorted 100 statements for self and ideal. Self–ideal correlation at the start averaged −.01, at the end of therapy .34, and .31 at follow-up; for the 17 most improved, .02 to .44. An own-control group stayed at −.01 over sixty days; the non-therapy control stayed at about .58. Even after therapy the self is "somewhat less valued" than in controls ("not … 'perfect adjustment'"). Other studies: it is the self, not the ideal, that changes; the ideal becomes "more achievable."

Does Psychotherapy Bring Change in Everyday Behavior?

- The layman's question. Using Willoughby's Emotional Maturity Scale (60 behavioral items, 1 to 9), the client and two friends rated behavior before, after and at follow-up. Overall observer ratings showed no significant change, "contrary to our hypothesis"; but in clients rated by counselors as showing most movement, friends' ratings rose (5 percent level), moderate little, least movement a decline. The least successful clients rated themselves as sharply more mature: "a defensive self-rating when therapy has not gone well." So unsuccessful therapy "can produce negative changes."

The Quality of the Therapeutic Relationship as Related to Movement in Therapy

- Barrett-Lennard's Relationship Inventory, given after the fifth interview, measured empathic understanding ("He tries to see things thru my eyes"), level of regard, unconditionality, congruence and willingness to be known. In the more disturbed clients, the first four correlated significantly with change, empathy most; willingness to be known did not. So a relationship of congruence, empathy, regard and unconditionality "will have a high probability of being an effective therapeutic relationship"; these are "primary change-producing influences," all "attitudinal." Perhaps "certain attitudinal and experiential qualities by themselves, regardless of intellectual knowledge or medical or psychological training, may be sufficient."

Some Current Research

- Shlien's time-limited therapy (twenty or forty interviews) and parallel Adlerian therapy; Cartwright, Fiske and Kirtner's broad search for factors; Wisconsin work on autonomic correlates during the hour; an operational scale from the process stages (Chapter 7); and a comparison, with Gendlin, of process in chronic and acute schizophrenic patients and normal persons.

The Meaning of Research for the Future

- Verified knowledge "will bring about the gradual demise of 'schools' of psychotherapy, including this one": there is no "penicillin school" in medicine. Therapy will have "neither … nor need any specific label." To those who abhor research as depersonalizing: "to date this has not been its effect." The paradox: to advance knowledge one must test "most passionate beliefs" impersonally, but to be effective the therapist "must use this knowledge only to enrich and enlarge his subjective self, and must be that self, freely and without fear."

How this chapter builds the author's case

Chapter 12 closes Part V by tying the research back to the conditions named in Part II (Barrett-Lennard tests the three conditions plus others) and the process of Part III (the stage scale, Thetford's autonomic change). Its last paradox returns to Chapter 10: science serves the person. Part VI now applies the same relationship conditions beyond therapy.

PART VI

What Are the Implications for Living?

The author's own description of the Part

> *"I have found the experience of therapy to have meaningful and sometimes profound implications for education, for interpersonal communication, for family living, for the creative process."*

The theme of the Part

If the conditions that foster growth in therapy are general, they should work elsewhere. Rogers applies them to the classroom, the family, communication between groups, relationships in general and creativity.

How the chapters build the theme

- Chapters 13–15 apply the conditions to teaching and learning, from his provocative personal statement, through a fuller formulation, to a participant's account.
- Chapter 16 takes them into family life.
- Chapter 17 takes them to breakdowns in communication between people and groups.
- Chapter 18 states a tentative general law of interpersonal relationships.
- Chapter 19 turns to the creative process and its conditions.

What the Part contributes to the book

It carries the book from the consulting room to everyday life, and shows the same attitudes of genuineness, acceptance and empathy as the basis of growth everywhere.

CHAPTER 13

Personal Thoughts on Teaching and Learning

Place in the argument

Rogers calls this "the shortest chapter in the book" and "the most explosive." It opens Part VI, "What Are the Implications for Living?", by moving from therapy to the classroom. He was asked to demonstrate "student-centered teaching" at a Harvard conference but thought a demonstration "highly artificial"; so he wrote down, "as honestly as I could," what his experience of teaching and learning had meant to him, as personal opinion rather than conclusion, and then accepted the group's reaction. The statement is lettered paragraphs in the first person, ending with implications.

- Having "immersed myself in the writings of Søren Kierkegaard" in Mexico, he put down his views. The meeting erupted ("I was threatening their jobs"), and he did not defend himself but "endeavored to accept and empathize with the indignation." Members then began "expressing, more and more frankly, their own significant feelings about teaching." One said next morning, "You kept more people awake last night!" He never felt it incendiary: "It still expresses some of my deepest views."
- Thinking about his experience "leads me, nearly always, in directions regarded as absurd." The views are "very tentative meanings, as of April 1952," "in no way intended as conclusions for someone else."
- (a) "I cannot teach another person how to teach." (b) "Anything that can be taught to another is relatively inconsequential, and has little or no significant influence on behavior." (c)–(e) He is interested only in learning that influences behavior, and "the only learning which significantly influences behavior is self-discovered, self-appropriated learning"; communicated directly, "it becomes teaching, and its results are inconsequential" (Kierkegaard found this too). (f)–(h) He has lost interest in being a teacher; when teaching succeeds, "the results are damaging. It seems to cause the individual to distrust his own experience." (i)–(l) He is "only interested in being a learner"; learning is rewarding in groups, in therapy or alone; best through dropping defensiveness to understand another's experience, and by stating "my own uncertainties." (m) This is "floating with a complex stream of experience."
- Implications, "if the experiences of others had been the same": do away with teaching ("People would get together if they wished to learn"), examinations ("they measure only the inconsequential type of learning"), grades and credits, degrees (a degree "marks an end," and a learner is interested in "the continuing process of learning"), and "the exposition of conclusions." He stops there, wanting to know "whether anything in my inward thinking … speaks to anything in your experience of the classroom."

How this chapter builds the author's case

This short, deliberately provocative statement opens Part VI by applying the trust in one's own experience of Chapter 1 and the self-appropriated learning of Chapter 10 to education. Chapter 14 states the same view in a form "less disturbing" but without dodging its radical implications.

CHAPTER 14

Significant Learning: In Therapy and in Education

Place in the argument

After the storm in Chapter 13, Rogers was asked to lead a Goddard College workshop (February 1958) on "The Implications of Psychotherapy for Education." He decided "to reformulate my views on teaching and learning … in a way which would be less disturbing than the statement in the preceding chapter, yet without dodging the radical implications." It is, he says, "the most satisfying formulation I have achieved of the meaning of the hypotheses of client-centered therapy in the field of education." The headings go from significant learning in therapy and in education, through the therapist's conditions, to implications, omissions and outcomes, then open issues.

- "This is a thesis, a point of view," held "tentatively, and with some hesitation," hoping it gives "a starting point from which clear differences can emerge."

Significant Learning in Psychotherapy

- "Learning which is more than an accumulation of facts. It is learning which makes a difference — in the individual's behavior, in the course of action he chooses in the future, in his attitudes and in his personality." Research shows the client sees himself differently, accepts himself, becomes more self-directing, flexible, realistic and mature, changes behaviors "even such a long-established one as chronic alcoholism," and is more open to evidence "inside" and "outside."

Significant Learning in Education

- Educators too want learnings that "make a difference," and are "a little embarrassed" by facts as education: his agronomy professor's "Don't be a damned ammunition wagon; be a rifle!" Education might look to therapy for leads.

The Conditions of Learning in Psychotherapy

- The five conditions are a restatement of Part II's; those who know Part II may skip to the implications.

Facing a Problem

- The client faces "a serious and meaningful problem" and has "an uncertain and ambivalent desire to learn or to change."

Congruence

- The therapist is "exactly what he is — not a façade, or a role, or a pretense": "this accurate matching of experience with awareness." With such a person we know "exactly where he stands"; with another we suspect "a front or a façade" and become "cautious and wary."

Unconditional Positive Regard

- "A warm caring for the client — a caring which is not possessive, which demands no personal gratification": "I care"; not "I care for you if you behave thus and so" (Standal's "unconditional positive regard"), including for "'bad,' painful, fearful, and abnormal feelings."

An Empathic Understanding

- "To sense the client's private world as if it were your own, but without ever losing the 'as if' quality." Fiedler's items: the therapist "is never in any doubt about what the patient means."

Fifth Condition

- The client must "experience or perceive something of the therapist's congruence, acceptance, and empathy."

The Process of Learning in Therapy

- When the five conditions exist, “a process of change inevitably occurs”: rigid perceptions loosen, the client questions the “facts” of his life, experiences feelings, and becomes “a more fluid, changing, learning person.”

The Mainspring of Change

- The motivation “springs from the self-actualizing tendency of life itself.” Summary: the five conditions listed.

Implications for Education

- “The task of the teacher is to create a facilitating classroom climate.”

Contact with Problems

- Significant learning comes “more readily in relation to situations perceived as problems”: more in workshops and extension courses than required courses, but also in regular classes “when a regular university class does perceive the course as an experience they can use to resolve problems.” He cites Russia and the Sputniks: a nation “faced with the urgent problem of being behind.” Let students “be in real contact with the relevant problems of his existence.”

The Teacher’s Real-ness

- A congruent teacher “can be enthusiastic about subjects he likes, and bored by topics he does not like,” and is “not a faceless embodiment of a curricular requirement, or a sterile pipe.” Teachers who helped his own learning “each one has this quality of being a real person.”

Acceptance and Understanding

- A teacher who gives “unconditional positive regard” and empathizes with “fear, anticipation, and discouragement” sets the conditions; Moustakas’ *The Teacher and the Child*. Feelings about parents or siblings have “a definite relationship to the learning of long division or the geography of Pakistan.”

Provision of Resources

- In therapy the resources lie within; in education knowledge exists, so materials should “be made available to the students, not forced upon them.” The teacher offers his knowledge, even lectures, “as an offer, which could as readily be refused as accepted,” and is a “resource-finder.” His feelings are “offerings,” not “commands, or impositions.”

The Basic Motive

- Reliance on “the self-actualizing tendency in his students”: those in contact with problems “wish to learn, want to grow, seek to find out, hope to master, desire to create.”

Some Omissions

- No imposed lectures (a requested lecture is different; “his response to their feelings … would take precedence over his interest in expounding material”) and no teacher’s examinations: “In therapy, the examinations are set by life.” The teacher supplies the requirements set by life (math for engineering school, a driving test). Evaluation as “a ticket of entrance, not … a club over the recalcitrant.” Lecture and evaluation are “the two major ingredients of current education,” so the implications are “startling indeed.”

Probable Outcomes

- Studies (inadequate, a few months, one a year with lower-status children): factual learning “roughly equal” to conventional classes; greater gains in personal adjustment, self-initiated learning, creativity and self-responsibility. But findings “will never answer our questions,” as they must be judged by our goals: if we value knowledge alone we may discard this; if creativity and independence (and not conformity), we may try it.

Some Concluding Issues

- Goals; actual outcomes ("rigorous, hard-headed research"); whether we can let youth "come in contact with real issues" when our culture keeps them from work and responsibility; whether knowledge may be "organized in and by the individual" (Hoover: "you simply cannot expect kids of those ages to determine the sort of education they need"); the trend toward drill in facts (Rickover's "uniform standards"; Lerner's "tools"); and Skinner's teaching machines, which he expects to spread, so "we must come to terms" with them. "It is not a time when timid answers will suffice."

How this chapter builds the author's case

Chapter 14 builds on Chapter 13 and on Chapters 2–4 by applying the five conditions to teaching, and prepares Chapter 15's account of one course taught this way. The claim that evaluation should come from life and that learners must face real problems is tested in practice there.

Student-Centered Teaching as Experienced by a Participant

Place in the argument

Rogers does not want to give only his own view of education; as with therapy he wants "the student's perception," the "raw material" from which he formed his views. Instead of excerpts from many reaction sheets he prints two documents by Dr. Samuel Tenenbaum: an account written just after Rogers' four-week Brandeis course (summer 1958), and a letter a year later about Tenenbaum's own teaching. The point is that it is not "simply the personality of a specific teacher" but "the operation of certain principles" that any facilitator may use.

- Rogers had "no great expectations"; the group was heterogeneous and mature, and he felt "very relaxed." Perhaps because of the modest expectations, it went so well: "among the most satisfying of my attempts to facilitate learning."
- A digression: he has more assurance with a new client than a new group. Sometimes a promising course fails to produce "vital, self-initiated, self-directed learning," and a doubtful one goes "extremely well," so "our formulation of the process of facilitating learning in education is not nearly as accurate or complete" as that of therapy.
- He chose Tenenbaum, "a mature scholar," author of a Kilpatrick biography; he did not share all his perceptions, which made them useful. Teachers who have lived this "can never return to more stereotyped ways of education."

Carl R. Rogers and Non-Directive Teaching

- Tenenbaum, shaped by Kilpatrick and Dewey, was "not prepared for anything that proved so overwhelming": a method "so radically different from the customary and the accepted, so undermining of the old."

Unstructured Approach

- "The course was altogether unstructured; and it was exactly that." Rogers sat with some 25 students and suggested they state purposes; after strained silence they spoke, and "at no time did the instructor urge any student to speak." He brought reprints, books, tapes and films, asking only for a volunteer to set them up; students arranged the rest.
- Then "four hard, frustrating sessions": random talk, "chaotic, aimless, a waste of time." Students demanded the traditional role: "Had they not come from far distances to learn from the oracle himself?" Yet they felt joined, and had "communicated as never before in any classroom." Rogers "took many blows" but had "a 'whim of steel.'" A student said: "We are Rogers-centered, not student-centered."

Encouraging Thinking

- A student, using Dewey and Kilpatrick, said Rogers wanted independent thinking and the "reconstruction" of the person, not an end-term examination; he proposed students set up problems. Rogers answered only, "I see you feel strongly about this?" Pressed to lecture, he read an unpublished paper for over an hour, "dull and soporific to the extreme," which "squelched all further demands for lecturing."
- By the fifth session students "by-passed Rogers" and became "an interacting group." Cause, conjecturally: for four sessions they refused to believe he would not play the traditional role; then they saw "it was they who had to provide the content — an uncomfortable, challenging situation indeed."

Importance of Acceptance

- Where a person is accepted with no judgment, he can "give up his defenses and face his true self"; "moments of therapy" appeared. It "was learning and therapy," a healthy change in flexibility and openness. Tenenbaum saw "hard, inflexible, dogmatic persons" become "sympathetic, understanding," with a student saying "I don't believe I ever learned so much anywhere."

- Not merely emotional: students read more than in any other course, the room was occupied until ten at night. Waste of time “may be necessary”; he doubts he could have learned “as much or as well or as thoroughly” in a traditional class. Not 100 per cent successful: three or four students disliked it, wanting “a rounded-out intellectual piece of merchandise.” It “can be threatening” to the authoritarian person.

A New Methodology

- The ferment came from “lack of closure”: Rogers “never summarizes,” and even the grade is suggested by the student, so there is no “end.” Staking their persons produced closeness, such as a cookout, a plan for a publication, and a visit to a mental hospital. He calls the approach “truly a creative addition to classroom methodology,” to be tried “in every area of learning,” since education as “the reconstruction of experience” means the individual must do his own reconstructing.

A Personal Teaching Experience (as reported to Dr. Rogers one year later)

- Tenenbaum had “a phobia about teaching,” rooted in his role as “the motivator, director and the production chief of a performance.” Teaching a 14-session June course for Yeshiva University, he admitted “weaknesses, doubts, dilemmas, and NOT KNOWING” and found himself talking “easily and even creatively.”
- He now sees that his earlier discussions were never real: “all of them were loaded,” and students were “instruments by which situations were manipulated.” This time he “really listened,” gave “understanding and sympathy,” never referred to his notes, and set no fixed requirements. He regrets lecturing at times, because students then “try to guess what is in the instructor’s head.”
- The result: “an unparalleled experience”; he liked these students “as I have never liked any other group,” faculty wanted to sit in, and the Dean wrote to him. Later groups were similar, with students planning “annual reunions,” and describing “radical and fundamental changes in their person.” He questions whether the traditional set-up has “a place for the ‘becoming’ person.”

How this chapter builds the author’s case

After the theory of Chapters 13–14, Chapter 15 gives the student’s side of the same ideas, tested in a real course. It shows the order of events (frustration, then group responsibility, then closeness) and the claim that the principles can be used by any facilitator, which Chapter 16 takes further for the individual.

CHAPTER 16

The Implications of Client-Centered Therapy for Family Life

Place in the argument

Rogers had long said that therapy bears on "every area of interpersonal relationships" but had never spelled out what it means for "that closest of all interpersonal circles — the family group." He will not argue about models of family life or tell anyone how to live; he reports how clients changed in their family relationships, drawing "heavily on the verbatim statements of these people." The headings give four changes, followed by a general summary.

- The question: "What then, are some of the ways in which clients change in their family living, as a consequence of client-centered therapy?" Some of the experience "runs counter to current concepts of what is involved in constructive family living," but he is "not particularly interested in arguing these differences."

More Expressive of Feeling

- Clients come "to express more fully … their true feelings," negative (resentment, anger, jealousy) and positive (tenderness, love): "as though the client discovers in therapy that it is possible to drop the mask." Expression now "matches more closely the territory of the actual emotional experience."
- Mrs. M. (a young wife) told her husband the guilt she had hidden. He was "very accepting"; "I TRUST HIM." She found that "as she had experienced in therapy the satisfaction of being herself," she could not behave differently at home.
- Expression, once "destructive and disastrous," now satisfies. Behind a façade, feelings pile up and explode inappropriately; once the client has poured them out and owned them, "they lose their explosiveness," and later feelings are "more appropriate, and more likely to be understood."

Relationships Can Be Lived on a Real Basis

- Clients find that a relationship "can be lived on the basis of the real feelings, rather than … a defensive pretense." Saying "What you are doing is all wrong" leads to debate, but "I feel very much annoyed by what you're doing" states "a fact which no one can deny."
- Mrs. S. lived with her domineering mother and ten-year-old daughter, feeling guilty and resentful. She said, "Well, why not face it? … okay, I resent her." She acted calmly and took night courses; her mother's "heart attack" was met with the doctor's verdict that she was fine. Later: "I've also found myself … feeling a little affectionate toward her." Rogers: "the relationship improves rather than deteriorates"; resentment is not the only feeling.
- Mr. K., a young professional man, found positive feelings as hard: he could once "talk about Judy" but with "some unreal quality." Now "I do think she is the most wonderful kid in the world," and he can also show annoyance. "The feelings which exist are good enough to live by."

Improvement in Two-Way Communication

- To understand another and be understood "is one of the most rewarding of human experiences, and all too rare." Clients want to extend what they got from the counselor's understanding. Also, living behind a façade, "we dare not listen freely to another"; once not defensive, they can "really listen to, and understand" and "let himself see how life appears to this other person."
- Mrs. S., having accepted her feelings, now draws out her daughter Carol, neither condemning nor praising, and "it's working out fine."

Willingness for Another to Be Separate

- "a most radical step": letting each family member "have his own feelings and … be a separate person." We often press others to share our feelings ("If you want me to love you, then you must have the same feelings I do"). Rogers believes this arises when the person "can trust his own feelings," so can trust wife or child.

- A mother who read *Client-Centered Therapy* stopped taking “responsibility for his goals” for her 14-year-old son, and his father wrote, “he began to blossom when I finally began to trust him to be himself.”
- Rogers imagines a child never forced to disown his feelings “in order to be loved”: respecting himself, “responsible and self-directing,” never needing “to live behind a façade.”

The General Picture

- It is satisfying in the long run to express strong feelings “in the situation in which they arise, to the person with whom they are concerned, and to the depth to which they exist,” and to live a relationship on real feelings; the fear that this destroys the relationship “is usually unfounded,” particularly when feelings are owned as one’s own. Defenses drop, understanding grows, and “as I am more willing to be myself, I find I am more ready to permit you to be yourself.”
- Final claim: a therapy that helps a person become himself also brings greater satisfaction in family relationships that “facilitat[e] each member of the family in the process of discovering, and becoming, himself.”

How this chapter builds the author’s case

Having tried the principles in school (Chapters 13–15), Rogers tests them in the home. The four changes (openness about feeling, relationships on real feelings, two-way listening, permitting separateness) are the family version of congruence, acceptance and empathy from Part II. Chapter 17 applies them to group tensions.

CHAPTER 17

Dealing With Breakdowns in Communication — Interpersonal and Intergroup

Place in the argument

The earliest paper in the book (1951, Northwestern University's Centennial Conference on Communications, first titled "Communication: Its Blocking and Its Facilitation"). Rogers includes it because it makes "an important point regarding group tensions, national and international"; its suggestion on Russian–U.S. tensions, "hopelessly idealistic" then, he thinks many would now call "good sense." It has no sub-headings; it moves from a hypothesis about the barrier, to the remedy, to the obstacles, to a summary.

- Why should a psychotherapist care about communication? "The whole task of psychotherapy is the task of dealing with a failure in communication." The neurotic's inner communication is blocked, which distorts his communication with others. Hence "psychotherapy is good communication, within and between men," and the reverse: "Good communication, free communication, within or between men, is always therapeutic."
- The barrier: "our very natural tendency to judge, to evaluate, to approve or disapprove, the statement of the other person, or the other group." Told "I didn't like that man's talk," we answer with approval or disapproval. The tendency grows with feeling, so two sides are "missing each other in psychological space."
- The remedy: "Real communication occurs … when we listen with understanding," meaning "to see the expressed idea and attitude from the other person's point of view." This is "understanding with a person, not about him," and "the most effective agent we know for altering the basic personality structure."
- A test: in an argument, "Each person can speak up for himself only after he has first restated the ideas and feelings of the previous speaker accurately, and to that speaker's satisfaction." It is "one of the most difficult things you have ever tried," but the emotion goes out of the discussion. The same in a labor–management dispute.
- Why it is rarely used: first, courage, since "you run the risk of being changed yourself." Second, strong emotion makes it hardest when needed most, but a neutral third party who is "a catalyst" can listen to each side; statements "grow less exaggerated and less defensive." Third, experience is with small face-to-face groups; larger or remote groups are unknown ("a tentative test-tube solution"). Fourth, society lacks faith in the social sciences (the wartime synthetic-rubber effort is his contrast).
- His thought experiment: an international therapeutically oriented group states each side's views and feelings to its satisfaction, and distributes both widely.
- Summary: the procedure "can be initiated by one party, without waiting for the other to be ready"; defensive distortions "drop away with astonishing speed as people find that the only intent is to understand, not judge"; it turns attention to solving the problem, not attacking a person or group. He asks whether this small-scale answer can be applied to failures of communication that "threaten the very existence of our modern world."

How this chapter builds the author's case

Chapters 15 and 16 gave classroom and family. Chapter 17 carries empathic listening beyond to groups and nations, ending Part VI's run of applications and preparing Chapter 18, where the same ideas are put in the form of a broader theory of interpersonal relationships.

CHAPTER 18

A Tentative Formulation of a General Law of Interpersonal Relationships

Place in the argument

Rogers had "tantalized" himself with whether one hypothesis could state what makes any relationship growth-facilitating or the reverse. He drafted it privately and tried it on a workshop and on industrial executives, who found it stimulating. He calls it "highly tentative," and includes it because many found it provocative and because it may "inspire research studies." It spells out one aspect of his theory of interpersonal relationships: an "underlying orderliness" that decides whether both people grow or both become defensive.

- Question behind it: how "our learnings in the field of psychotherapy apply to human relationships in general."

The Concept of Congruence

- "Congruence is the term we have used to indicate an accurate matching of experiencing and awareness," extended to "a matching of experience, awareness, and communication." The infant hungry or content is "one unified person all the way through."
- Incongruence: the man who angrily says "I'm not angry! … I was just pointing out the logical facts" while the group laughs. His words give logic, his tone and gestures say "I am angry at you." Communication from an incongruent person is marked by "ambiguity or contradictoriness," and he cannot judge his own congruence at that moment; later, safe in therapy, he may see it.
- Experience versus awareness is "defensiveness, or denial to awareness"; awareness versus communication (Mrs. Brown, bored, saying "It was a delightful party") is "falseness or deceit."
- A corollary: a wholly congruent person "could not say, 'That rock is hard'; 'He is stupid'; 'You are bad,'" since we never experience such "facts" but only perceptions from an internal frame of reference. The reverse does not follow, since speaking from personal perception can itself be defensive.
- In commonsense terms, with congruent people "we know exactly where he stands"; with others we sense "a front, a facade" and become "wary and cautious." Degree of congruence varies between people and between moments.

Relating Congruence to Communication in Interpersonal Relationships

- A chain of twelve steps for "Smith and Jones": Smith's congruence makes his message clear; Jones responds more clearly; Smith, with less to defend, listens accurately; Jones feels empathically understood, which makes him feel positive regard for Smith; and experiences the conditions of therapy (Smith congruent, regarding, empathic). His defensiveness falls and he communicates more congruently and listens better. Then the same happens for Smith: they "become reciprocally therapeutic for each other," with integration, less conflict and more mature behavior.
- The limit (step 12): threatening material. If Jones touches an area where Smith is incongruent, Smith defends, becomes ambiguous, "and the whole process … begins to occur in reverse."

A Tentative Statement of a General Law

- With a minimal willingness to be in contact, to receive communication, and contact over time: "The greater the congruence of experience, awareness and communication on the part of one individual, the more the ensuing relationship will involve" reciprocal communication of increasing congruence, more accurate understanding, improved adjustment in both, and mutual satisfaction. Conversely, communicated incongruence leads to disintegration of understanding and "mutual dissatisfaction."
- Stated more exactly, it is the receiver's perception that matters: "The more that Y experiences the communication of X as a congruence …", a hypothesis which can be tested, since Y's perception "should not be too difficult to measure."

The Existential Choice

- Client and therapist alike ask: “Do I dare to communicate the full degree of congruence which I feel?” Because of threat or rejection, it is a risk, and “the taking or not taking of this risk … determines whether a given relationship becomes more and more mutually therapeutic or … disintegrative.”
- “I cannot choose whether my awareness will be congruent with my experience” (that is settled by unconscious defense); “but there is a continuing existential choice as to whether my communication will be congruent with the awareness I do have.”

How this chapter builds the author’s case

This is the theory behind Chapters 16–17: congruence, regard and empathy, which Part II described as the therapist’s conditions, are shown to work between any two people. It moves Part VI from applications toward principle, and the stress on risk and choice leads into Part VII’s questions about science and the person.

CHAPTER 19

Toward a Theory of Creativity

Place in the argument

Prompted by a December 1952 Ohio State Conference on Creativity (artists, writers, dancers, educators, philosophers, psychiatrists, psychologists), Rogers expanded his rough notes into this paper. He holds that there is "a desperate social need for the creative behavior of creative individuals," which justifies a tentative theory of the nature of the creative act, the conditions under which it occurs, and how it may be fostered, as "a stimulus and guide to research."

- (The author's opening paragraph is the statement of purpose above.)

The Social Need

- Our culture shows "a dearth of creativity": education turns out "conformists, stereotypes"; leisure is passive; science has "technicians" but few who can form fruitful theories; industry reserves creation for the few; in daily life "to be original, or different, is felt to be 'dangerous.'"
- It matters because knowledge is advancing "into a fantastic atomic age": "Unless man can make new and original adaptations to his environment as rapidly as his science can change the environment, our culture will perish."

The Creative Process

- It needs "some observable product," a "novel construction" arising from "the unique qualities of the individual in his interaction with the materials of experience." No difference of process between painting, devising "new instruments of killing," a scientific theory, or "new formings of one's own personality as in psychotherapy," which gives Rogers confidence in everyone's creative potential.
- Definition: "the emergence in action of a novel relational product, growing out of the uniqueness of the individual on the one hand, and the materials, events, people, or circumstances of his life on the other." It omits social value (Galileo and Copernicus were judged "blasphemous and wicked"), group acceptance, and degree (child, Einstein, the housewife's new sauce are all creative).

The Motivation for Creativity

- Its mainspring is the self-actualizing tendency, "the urge to expand, extend, develop, mature," buried under defenses but present in every individual.
- Social value cannot be judged by the product (the more original, the more likely "judged by contemporaries as evil") or by the creator's purposes (many valuable creations came from personal interest, while Utopias and Prohibition aimed at the social good). The individual creates "because it is satisfying to him."
- Hope from therapy: when the person is "open" to all his experience, "his creativity may be trusted to be essentially constructive." Someone denying large areas of experience may create something "pathological, or socially evil, or both" (a paranoid theory); Socrates, "notably nondefensive," created what proved constructive. The more open the person is, "the nature of the human species tends in the direction of constructively social living."

The Inner Conditions of Constructive Creativity

- A. Openness to experience: Extensionality. The opposite of defensiveness: each stimulus is freely relayed, without "predetermined categories" ("trees are green" versus "this tree is lavender"); "a tolerance for ambiguity where ambiguity exists." Openness to only one phase (the tyrant's to others' weaknesses) can yield destructive creations.
- B. An internal locus of evaluation. "Have I created something satisfying to me? Does it express a part of me?" The value of the product is established "not by the praise or criticism of others, but by himself."
- C. The ability to toy with elements and concepts. Less important than A and B, but spontaneous play with ideas yields "the hunch, the creative seeing of life in a new and significant way."

The Creative Act and Its Concomitants

- With these three conditions, constructive creativity occurs, but the act itself is “indescribable,” “the improbable that becomes probable.” One quality is selectivity: the “I” brings a structure to reality, giving products “their esthetic quality.”
- Concomitants: the “Eureka feeling”; “the anxiety of separateness” (“I have ventured into territory where no one has been”); and the desire to communicate, since “He does not create in order to communicate, but once having created he desires to share.”

Conditions Fostering Constructive Creativity

- These cannot be forced (the farmer “can only supply the nurturing conditions”), but can be fostered by X, psychological safety, and Y, psychological freedom.
- X1. Accepting the individual as of unconditional worth; X2. Providing a climate in which external evaluation is absent, since “Evaluation is always a threat”; “I don’t like your idea” is “a reaction,” not a judgment from an external source; X3. Understanding empathically: “If I understand you empathically … and still accept you — then this is safety indeed.”
- Y. Complete freedom of symbolic expression (destroying a symbol of a hated object frees; attacking it in reality “may create guilt”), a point he marks “I feel unsure of this paragraph.” Such permissiveness “is not softness or indulgence”; it means “responsibly to be oneself.”

Conclusion

- He offers the theory as “an orderly way of thinking” for rigorous testing, since “the present development of the physical sciences is making an imperative demand upon us … for creative behavior in adapting ourselves to our new world if we are to survive.”

How this chapter builds the author’s case

Creativity is the same self-actualizing tendency as in therapy, now with a social stake. The conditions (safety, absence of evaluation, empathy, freedom) are those of Chapters 14 and 17 applied to creating, and “openness to experience” and “internal locus of evaluation” link back to Chapter 9’s person and forward to Chapter 20’s view of values.

PART VII

The Behavioral Sciences and the Person

The author's own description of the Part

> *"I feel a deep concern that the developing behavioral sciences may be used to control the individual and to rob him of his personhood. I believe, however, that these sciences might be used to enhance the person."*

The theme of the Part

Who will decide the purposes to which the growing power of the behavioral sciences is put? Rogers shows the power, states the danger, and offers a choice of values.

How the chapters build the theme

- Chapter 20 sketches the growing ability of the behavioral sciences to predict and control, and asks questions of power and purpose.
- Chapter 21 describes two responses, points out that values lie outside science, and proposes an alternative set of values based on process and becoming.

What the Part contributes to the book

It closes the book by making the person prior to science, so that the trust in persons earned in therapy shapes how science is used.

CHAPTER 20

The Growing Power of the Behavioral Sciences

Place in the argument

Invited by B. F. Skinner, Rogers debated him at the 1956 American Psychological Association convention (published in *Science*, 30 Nov 1956) on using scientific knowledge to control behavior. Dissatisfied that it was "a debate" with a tone "of an either-or variety," he wrote his own view at greater length over the next year, in two chapters. This one shows what the behavioral sciences can already do and what questions follow; Chapter 21 gives his tentative resolution. Skinner's stance was that psychologists are "curiously diffident in assuming control."

- The behavioral sciences are "in an infant state," with "more confusion than solid knowledge," yet "a mighty stride toward becoming an 'if — then' science." Few see how far this has gone, and fewer "the profound social, educational, political, economic, ethical, and philosophical problems posed by these advances." His aims: sketch the growing ability to understand, predict and control; point out the problems; suggest a resolution.

The "Know-How" of the Behavioral Sciences

- His samples are selective, favor psychology and stress prediction and control; each statement is stated simply and is "an expression of a given degree of probability, not of some absolute truth."

Prediction of Behaviors

- We can predict who will succeed as college students, executives, salesmen, officers or combat soldiers. Williams and Leavitt found a Marine's "buddies" better instruments than objective tests. Corporations test how radical or conservative executives are, and their "latent hostility" or "psychotic tendencies" (Whyte); a short test predicts troublemakers among store employees.
- Meehl: a clerk with test scores and actuarial tables describes personality better than an experienced clinician, and "there is no reason why Meehl's clerk could not also be eliminated" by a computer. We can also pick the easily persuaded or conforming (TAT studies), and tell prejudice from how people judge the movement of a spot of light in a dark room (Block and Block). Such developments "can also cause a cold chill of apprehension" (von Bertalanffy: "the dangers of psychological technology are often overlooked").

Conditions Followed by Specified Behaviors in Groups

- Participation in decisions and non-authoritarian supervision raise production and morale (Coch and French; Katz, Maccoby and Morse). Leaders who are acceptant, empathic and give responsibility to the group (Gordon, Richard) bring personality growth and better group function. Beier: students given a Rorschach personality evaluation became more rigid and worse at abstract reasoning, "very similar to many evaluations made in our schools." Advertising and depth interviews exploit unconscious motives (instant-coffee example).

Conditions Which Produce Specified Effects in Individuals

- Asch and Crutchfield: people can be led to deny their senses under group pressure, and the yielders can be selected. Subliminal flashes of "angry" or "happy" alter how a face is seen. Drugs change moods, and Skinner predicts normal motivation will be "maintained in any desired state through the use of drugs" ("somewhat exaggerated"). McGill sensory deprivation produces hallucinations in forty-eight hours. Cameron's tape "psychic driving" penetrates defenses, and can be "dangerously disorganizing."
- His own field: when the therapist is genuine, acceptant and empathic, clients become more realistic, self-directing, positively self-valued, less repressed, more mature, and less upset by stress; controls do not change. And the reverse: "We know how to disintegrate a man's personality structure," as in Communist "brainwashing" (Hinkle and Wolff), which is "largely a somewhat horrifying reversal of the conditions of psychotherapy." Knowledge "can be used constructively or destructively, to build or to destroy persons."

Conditions Which Produce Specified Effects in Animals

- Imprinting in ducklings (devotion to "an old shoe"); electro-convulsive shock removing a conditioned fear in rats; Skinner's pigeons guiding a missile and operant "shaping," which also raised human subjects' plural nouns without awareness; Olds' rats bar-pressing for electrodes in the brain "until he is exhausted."

The General Picture and Its Implications

- "Deeply frightening aspects": leaders and followers selected, persons "developed … or weakened and disintegrated," and "a nightmare of manipulation," "wild fantasy, but … not an impossible fantasy." Oppenheimer: control of behavior "will pose far graver problems than any the physicists have posed."
- Few findings are used yet, as with flight around 1900; the public ignores a science, then finds it "more dependable than common sense," money flows in, and it grows fast. So findings little used today will be used widely tomorrow.

The Questions

- A science whose power "will make atomic energy seem feeble by comparison." How shall we use it? What happens to the individual in this "brave new world"? Who will hold the power? Toward what end or value? He leaves them to the next chapter.

How this chapter builds the author's case

Part VII, "The Behavioral Sciences and the Person," opens with the case for taking seriously the power of science over persons. Rogers' own findings on therapy are part of that power, so the next chapter must say who decides purposes. This chapter sets the problem; Chapter 21 gives his answer.

CHAPTER 21

The Place of the Individual in the New World of the Behavioral Sciences

Place in the argument

The second lecture. Having shown the power of the behavioral sciences, Rogers asks how individuals, groups and the culture will respond to "this brave new world." He describes two answers, then offers "a third." The headings follow that course: two attitudes (the second developed through its steps and implications), his personal reaction, the flaw he sees, and an alternative set of values with a small example.

- Question: "What stance will we take in the face of these new developments?"

Deny and Ignore

- One may deny that a science of behavior is possible (an economist; a theologian: "no scientific investigation of past behavior can become the basis of predictions of future behavior"), or, like the public, simply ignore it, even Whyte's revelations. These reactions "do not seem particularly intelligent."

The Formulation of Human Life in Terms of Science

- The sophisticated view, taken for granted by most behavioral scientists, who have thought little about it. Skinner urges using control; *Walden Two* is his fictional Utopia; Huxley's *Brave New World* and Orwell's *1984* are the benevolent and malignant forms. Assumptions: scientific knowledge is the power to manipulate; "some kind of control of human affairs is inevitable" (Skinner); and the power will be used.

Steps in the Process

- First, selection of goals ("Let man be happy, informed, skillful, well-behaved, and productive"; in *Walden Two*: "Give me the specifications, and I'll give you the man!"). Second, controlled experimentation to find the means, which is "self-correcting." Third, power: some person or group will hold it, and scientists are likely to be like the German rocket scientists serving whoever has them. Fourth, exposure of individuals to the conditions: positive reinforcement produces control under which "the controlled … nevertheless feel free"; "we control not the final behavior, but the inclination to behave."

The Picture and Its Implications

- Behavioral science advances; power is held by some one or some group, which chooses the goals; most of us are controlled "by means so subtle we will not even be aware of them." Whether a "council of wise psychologists," "a Stalin or a Big Brother" has the power, "some form of completely controlled society — a Walden Two or a 1984 — is coming," probably piecemeal.
- Skinner: "The hypothesis that man is not free is essential to the application of scientific method," the individual's contribution "appears to approach zero," and the democratic idea of man is out of date.

A Personal Reaction

- This world "would destroy the human person as I have come to know him in the deepest moments of psychotherapy," a person "spontaneous" and "responsibly free." If man becomes "a robot," "I am very unhappy indeed"; the conditioned good life is "a pseudo-form of the good life which includes everything save that which makes it good." He sees a flaw in the logic.

Ends and Values in Relation to Science

- Two-pronged thesis: (1) every scientific undertaking, pure or applied, rests on a prior "personal subjective choice" of the value it serves; (2) this choice "must always lie outside of that endeavor, and can never become a part of the science."

- The paradox: science assumes behavior is caused, yet each scientific step rests on "a personal subjective choice." Science can study values, "but only … in terms of some other value which I have subjectively chosen"; Russian geneticists had to choose between truth and dogma.
- Consequence: a society that controls behavior toward fixed goals is "locked in a colossal rigidity" because its science "cannot transcend itself to select new goals." If free "planners" are set aside, the rest are "slaves." Science does not evolve its own purposes, since personal choice enters each time direction changes.

An Alternative Set of Values

- Choose openly values of process: "Man as a process of becoming," the individual as "a self-actualizing process," "creatively adapts to an ever-new and changing world," knowledge that "transcends itself" (relativity over Newton). Then ask different questions of science: richer living, more meaningful relationships, releasing creativity, and whether science can "predict and release an essentially 'unpredictable' freedom."

A Small Example

- Therapy can be "one of the most subtle tools for the control of one person by another" (brainwashing is its extreme). Client-centered therapists too predict and influence behavior, setting conditions (genuine, acceptant, empathic) with little voice for the client, but these predict "internal control by the individual, in pursuit of internally chosen goals," behavior "essentially 'free.'" Findings: more mature, self-responsible, flexible, with behavior "harmonious, not chaotic." With Dewey: "Science has made its way by releasing, not by suppressing, the elements of variation."

A Possible Concept of the Control of Human Behavior

- Five steps parallel to the earlier ones: choose to value man as becoming; find the conditions by science; set them "with a minimum of power or control" (authority only to establish certain qualities of relationship); individuals become more self-responsible and creatively adaptive; a system whose values and even concept of science keep "changing and self-transcending." No definable Utopia; it points to Popper's "open society," the opposite of *Walden Two*'s closed one.

The Choice

- We can use the sciences to depersonalize and enslave, to make men "submissive, conforming, docile," or "free, not control." We must live with the paradox: determinism is "the great fact of science," but responsible personal choice "exists prior to any scientific endeavor"; like the wave and corpuscular theories of light, both are true. Closing: "the human person, with his capacity of subjective choice, can and will always exist, separate from and prior to any of his scientific undertakings. Unless … we choose to relinquish our capacity of subjective choice, we will always remain free persons, not simply pawns of a self-created behavioral science."

> **How this chapter builds the author's case**
>
> This chapter answers Chapter 20 and ends the book. It makes values prior to science, and chooses the values that therapy discovered (process, becoming, self-direction), so the whole book's claim, that the person is to be trusted and enabled, becomes also a claim about how science should be used.

Not summarised

These parts of the book are reference material, not argument, and have no notes here:

- Appendix: A Chronological Bibliography of the Publications of Carl R. Rogers, 1930–1960.
- Acknowledgments.
- Index.
- The reference lists at the end of Chapters 17, 18, 19, 20 and 21, and the chapters' footnotes.
- The title pages, copyright page and book's own table of contents.